Tuesday, February 20, 2024
Fagun 8, 2080 | Nepal Sambat 1144 | Shillathwo Ekadashi

NATION'S 1ST ENGLISH BROADSHEET

risingnepaldaily.com
Vol. LIX, No. 66 | Pages 8 | Rs. 5 | National Edition

THE RISING NEPAL

ALL BE HAPPY, ALL BE WELL



PHOTO: RSS

President Ramchandra Paudel, Vice President Ramsahay Prasad Yadav, Prime Minister Pushpa Kamal Dahal 'Prachanda' and other dignitaries attending the special function organised on the occasion of the 74th National Democracy Day at the Army Pavilion in Tundikhel, Kathmandu on Monday.

PM: Democracy foundation of advancement

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Feb. 19

Prime Minister Pushpa Kamal Dahal 'Prachanda' has emphasised the transformative potential of the federal democratic system and the need to harness it as an opportunity.

Speaking at a special function of the 74th National Democracy Day organised at the Army Pavilion in Tundikhel on Monday, Prime Minister Prachanda underscored the importance of building a robust foundation for socialism while concurrently defending and strengthening the federal democratic republic.

By 2026, Nepal aims to elevate itself from a least developed nation to a developing one, with Prime Minister Prachanda asserting that the nation has a responsibility to achieve qualitative growth in the gross domestic product.

"The traditional development model will be reevaluated with a focus on production and job creation," stated the Prime Minister. "Creating employment opportunities will deter brain drain, infusing the youth with a stream of hope and breaking Nepal free from the vicious cycle of poverty," said PM Prachanda.

Prime Minister Prachanda highlighted democracy as a system that lays the groundwork for political, economic, social, and cultural development by increasing public interest. He expressed confidence that a democratic system, where the people elect and send representatives to govern themselves, will provide a foundation for progress and advancement in the state.

Acknowledging that advanced democracy is the only viable alternative, Prime Minister Prachanda asserted that addressing the limitations and weaknesses within the system can only be achieved from within.

"The foundation of socialism can only be laid through the strengthening of the democratic republic, institutional development, effective implementation of federalism, and active citizen participation in the state management process," affirmed Prime Minister Prachanda.

He further emphasised that the continual development and sustainability of democracy hinge on the awareness and acceptance of the people.

Prime Minister Prachanda said that through rule of law, value and recognition of human rights, gender equality, proportional inclusion, participation and social justice, public interest and public welfare can be built.

"At this time, I'm trying not to let the trust, hope and confidence of the Nepali citizens to establish a federal democratic republic weaken. I'm aware and serious about the need to take concrete steps to bring visible changes in the daily living standards of the people guaranteed by the constitution," said Prime Minister Prachanda.

Meanwhile, President Ramchandra Paudel joined the special ceremony organised at the Army Pavilion Tundikhel to mark Democracy Day.

On the occasion, a helicopter of the Nepali Army displayed a banner inscribed with National Democracy Day-2080, showered flowers and flew balloons. Also, a couple of pigeons as symbols of peace were flown and a march-past and band display were performed by the Nepali Army, Nepal Police, and Armed Police Force.

The ceremony was attended by Vice President Ramsahay Prasad Yadav, Speaker of the House of Representatives Devraj Ghimire, Chairperson of the National Assembly Ganesh Prasad Timilsina, Deputy Prime Ministers, Ministers, lawmakers, heads and officials of constitutional bodies, high-level government officials, representatives of diplomatic missions and various sectors of society.

Democracy Day was marked in all seven provinces and all districts. Province Chiefs, Chief Ministers and others addressed the programmes urging the political parties and people to be aware of the forces working against the democratic system. They also said that the state should improve its working styles to instill home among the people.

NC's Mahasamiti meeting begins

BY PALLAV BHUSAL
Godavari (Lalitpur), Feb. 19

The Mahasamiti meeting of Nepali Congress commenced on Monday at Godavari Sunrise Convention Centre in Lalitpur. The meeting, inaugurated by party President and former Prime Minister Sher Bahadur Deuba, began with a symbolic act of sprinkling water on the election symbol of tree of the party.

The primary theme of the gathering was captured by the slogan, 'Political stability, transformation, and innovation, freedom, justice, and equality are the policy commitment of Nepali Congress.' The meeting, scheduled to run until February 22, marks the first Mahasamiti meeting since the 14th general convention of the party held in December 2021.

In his opening address, Deuba paid respect to the martyrs who sacrificed their lives for democracy. He expressed deep respect for the leaders who played instrumental roles in shaping the Nepali Congress, including B.P. Koirala, Suvarna Shamsher, Ganeshman Singh, Krishna Prashad Bhattarai, Girija Prashad Koirala and Sushil Koirala.

Deuba also acknowledged the continuous efforts of party members in establishing, restoring, and defending democracy, despite facing hardships such as imprisonment and exile.

He highlighted the historical struggle of the Nepali Congress for democracy, emphasising the party's commitment to democratic values. He underlined the role of the party in various critical junctures of the nation, including the transformation of a 10-year armed conflict waged by the Maoists into peace and the leadership in writing the current constitution.

The party president expressed pride in the Nepali Congress's history and emphasised its responsibility in upholding democratic principles.

"I credit the Nepali Congress for its achievement in creating the current constitution as well as defending and implementing it effectively. It is important that we conduct a thorough evaluation of the constitution's implementation. This involves identifying problems, complications, and doubts to make necessary amendments without adversely affecting the form of government and fundamental characteristics of the constitution," said Deuba.

Speaking about the present political landscape, Deuba highlighted the party's participation in alliances and coalitions, emphasising that the current coalition was formed not merely for government formation but to protect the constitution. He pointed out that the defence of the constitution remains the primary agenda, and all documents presented in the Mahasamiti meeting echo this commitment.

"In recognising the mixed electoral system protected in our constitution, I acknowledge both its merits and demerits. Pointing out its positive aspect, I underscore the importance of ensuring proper representation for all castes and communities in our diverse country.

» SEE PAGE 6



PHOTO: KABIN ADHIKARI/TRN

Nepali Congress President and former Prime Minister Sher Bahadur Deuba and other leaders participating in the inaugural session of the NC's Mahasamiti meeting in Godavari, Lalitpur on Monday.

Victims urge swift action on transitional justice legislature

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Feb. 19

Victims' organisations and representatives from across Nepal convened in Kathmandu on Sunday, demanding immediate action on the Transitional Justice Act. The gathering of various victim communities pressed for the adoption of a victim-centred approach to treat the lingering wounds of the conflict.

The victims' community also submitted a memorandum to Prime Minister Pushpa Kamal Dahal Prachanda on Sunday evening after their conference and emphasized the urgent need to pass the transitional justice bill through parliamentary processes and establish a victim-centred commission without further delay.

In a press briefing on Monday, Ram Kumar Bhandari, a victim leader, explained that in the meeting with Prime Minister they underscored

» SEE PAGE 6

Formulation of media-related laws a priority: Minister Sharma



RSS
Kathmandu, Feb. 19

Minister for Communications and Information Technology Rekha Sharma has said that formulation of media-related laws is a priority of the present government.

Speaking at a ceremony organised at the Rastriya Samachar Samiti (RSS) Central Office on Monday on the occasion of the 63rd anniversary of RSS, Minister Sharma, also the government spokesperson, said that prevailing laws will be amended and new laws would be formulated as per the spirit of federalism.

"The government is working to carry out reforms by amending and drafting new laws as per the norms and spirit of federalism in cooperation with all the stakeholders related to the media," she said.

Minister Sharma also said that the Mass Media Reforms Advisory Committee had been formed to provide policy and legal recommendations for the restructuring of the mass media sector and the Nepal Media Council Bill and the Mass Media Bill had been prepared based on the report of the committee.

Stating that the government is serious about making the journalism and communications sector competitive, professional and accountable, Minister Sharma said it was necessary for the media to now play an important role in the transformation of people's living standards while helping preserve political achievements.

» SEE PAGE 6

Karnali Hospital among best in infrastructure

BY OUR CORRESPONDENT
Surkhet, Feb.19



Karnali Provincial Hospital has become one of the best in the country in terms of physical infrastructure. Despite being upgraded from a district hospital to a regional one, it faced challenges in receiving adequate funding from the state.

Even after undergoing various reforms and variations in titles, the hospital did not receive sufficient investment from the government. However, significant progress was made in upgrading the facility from a health centre to a district hospital in 2029 BS and further to a regional hospital in 2049 BS.

After the upgradation of the hospital as regional one, it began operating from the building of the former health training centre. Due to weak physical infrastructure, lack of necessary manpower, and shortage of medical equipment, the hospital remained as it was for a long time. The significant transformation was not seen even until the 2060 BS.

However, in recent years, significant improvements have been made, especially with the completion of a new building in May 2016 and the beginning of outpatient services. The influx of patients has been increasing gradually since then. Additionally, two prefabricated buildings were constructed to operate maternity and ICU/CCU services. According to the hospital director, Dr. Dambar Khadka, the hospital has made remarkable progress in terms of infrastructure and service delivery. The hospital's services have been expanded, and it has become a reliable provider of healthcare facilities to the people of Karnali Province and neighbouring areas.

Dr. Khadka emphasised the importance of leadership and external support in the development of the hospital. He mentioned that while individual efforts are crucial for development, collective support from both government and non-governmental organisations is equally vital. The hospital now boasts modern equipment and facilities, thanks to the collaboration of various stakeholders.

Dr. Khadka also highlighted the need for reforms within the hospital, including training for medical professionals and establishing a conducive environment for both patients and staff.

Moreover, the hospital has expanded its services to include complex treatments such as hip replacement, neurosurgery, spinal surgery, heart disease and trauma care. This has greatly enhanced healthcare accessibility for the residents of Karnali Province. According to Dr. Khadka, plans are underway to establish the hospital as a medical institute, which will further contribute to its development and prosperity.

Despite facing challenges such as a shortage of medical professionals, the hospital has been granted approval to recruit 75 doctors, including 50 consultants and 25 medical/dental officers. Last year, the hospital received support for the recruitment of 517 healthcare workers and staff, including permanent, contractual, and scholarship positions.

"We want to develop the provincial hospital into an academy of health sciences," said Khadka. Accordingly, the work has already been started, he added.

Khadka believes that the scope of development and prosperity of the hospital can be further widened if it is upgraded to an academy. The establishment of a medical institute is aimed to further enhance the hospital's development and broaden the scope of healthcare services.

Dr. Khadka said that with the introduction of MD/MS courses and nursing programmes, specialised manpower will be available and, further enrich the hospital's capabilities.



PHOTO: KEDRA TIMALSINA/TRN

The Agriculture Fair that concluded in Banepa of Kavre on Monday. Organisers informed about 70,000 persons visited the fair.

Best taxpayer award dragged into controversy

BY HARI KOIRALA
Urlabari, Feb. 19

The Purbeli Crusher Industry has opposed the process of awarding the best taxpayer award on the occasion of the 11th Municipal Assembly of Urlabari Municipality of Morang.

The municipality has honoured Siddhartha Aggregate Pvt. Ltd. of Urlabari-1 and Baijayanti Mishra, resident of Urlabari-4 among the regular and highest taxpayers since the fiscal year 2021/22.

Dhurba Chandra Parajuli, the proprietor of the Purbeli Crusher Industry, said that the award was distributed without doing the proper research so the municipality failed to award the most deserving, and the decisions taken in haste had discouraged the entrepreneurs.

The Purbeli Crusher Industry claimed that it had paid regular and highest taxes. It had paid Rs. 300,000 on September 7, 2022, Rs. 58,000 on September 14, Rs. 290,450 on July 2, 2023 and Rs. 384,012 on July 7.

The Purbeli Crusher Industry blamed the municipality for nepotism and favouritism. Parajuli urged the concerned authorities to correct such faulty decisions.

Bharat Adhikari, information officer of Urlabari Municipality, said that the decision of the municipality was correct and the municipality had awarded the most deserving industry and person, based on the tax paid by them over the three fiscal years.

According to the Revenue Section, the Purbeli Crusher paid only Rs. 940,000 in the fiscal year 2021/22 to 2023/24. Purbeli had paid Rs. 580,000 in the fiscal year 2021/22 and 2022/23 and Rs. 36,000 in the fiscal year 2023/24.

The municipality has said that the decision was taken after looking at the tax details paid in the last three fiscal years. Local industrialists have suggested the concerned authorities formulate a working procedure related to the awards and honours after the controversy arose over the best business awards and honours.

Only 39% revenue collected in seven months

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Feb. 19

Revenue of around Rs. 567.4 billion has been collected in the first seven months of the current fiscal year 2023/24. According to the daily report of the Financial Comptroller General Office under the Ministry of Finance, the revenue collection of the government during the review period stands at Rs. 567.4 billion which is 39.89 per cent of the initial annual target (Rs. 1,422.54 billion).

Out of the toral revenue collection, tax revenue stood at Rs. 510.4 billion or 39.1 per cent and non-tax revenue stood at Rs. 56.9 billion or 48.61 per cent of the annual target. Of the total revenue collection target of Rs 1,422.54 billion, Rs. 1,305.4 billion is to be raised under tax revenue and Rs. 117.06 billion under non-tax revenue in the current fiscal year.

During the review period of the current fiscal year, grants of only Rs. 2.75 billion have been received by the government. It is 5.52 per cent of the annual target of the government. The government has set an annual target of Rs. 49.94 billion grants for the current fiscal year.

However, the government has received Rs. 21.3 billion under other recipients in the first seven months of the current fiscal year. The revenue collection has increased by 7.12 per cent during the review period as compared to the same period last year.

The government had collected revenue of Rs. 529.68 billion during the first seven months of the last fiscal year 2022/23. During the review period, the total income of the government stood at Rs. 591.55 billion. This is 40.17 per cent of the annual receipts target of the government.

During the review period, the government has spent Rs. 686.75 billion budget.

The government is in deficit in the first seven months of the current fiscal year due to higher expenses than total income.

The government is in deficit of Rs. 95 billion during the review period. The government has spent only 39.21 per cent in the first seven months of the total budget of Rs. 1,751.31 billion for the current fiscal year.

Of the total budget expenses, capital expenditure stands only at 21.05 per cent of total allocation in the first seven months of the current fiscal year. Of the Rs. 302 billion allocated under capital expenditure, only Rs. 50.90 billion has been spent by February 12, 2024.

The recurrent expenditure of the government stood at 44.58 per cent (Rs. 509 billion) during the review period.

The government has allocated Rs. 1,141.78 billion under the heading of recurrent expenditure for the current fiscal year.

However, a week ago, the government had revised the income and expenditure target for the current fiscal year.

The Ministry of Finance has reduced the size of budget by about Rs. 221 billion to Rs. 1,530.26 billion for the current fiscal year. It is 87.38 per cent of the initially allocated budget.

By end of the current fiscal year, it is estimated that around Rs. 1,309.30 billion will be arranged form government sources (revenue and domestic borrowing) and Rs. 40.12 billion from foreign grants and Rs. 180.83 billion from foreign loans.

The government had set a target of raising Rs. 1,240 billion from revenue, Rs. 49.94 billion from foreign grants, Rs. 212 billion from foreign loans and Rs. 240 billion from domestic borrowing.

US SPENDING $1.5 BILLION TO MAKE COMPUTER CHIPS

AP
Washington, Feb. 19

The Biden administration said Monday that the government intends to provide $1.5 billion to the computer chip company GlobalFoundries to expand its domestic production in New York and Vermont.

The announcement is the third award of direct financial support for a semiconductor company under the 2022 CHIPS and Science Act. The law enables the government to invest more than $52 billion to revitalize the manufacturing of computer chips in the United States as well as advance research and development.

"The chips that GlobalFoundries will make in these new facilities are essential," Commerce Secretary Gina Raimondo said on a call with reporters. "They power sophisticated military equipment, electric vehicles. They assure smartphones have the latest features, enable faster Internet connections for Americans." In addition to the direct funding, the government would also provide loans worth up to $1.6 billion, with a total combination of public and private investment expected to equal roughly $12.5 billion.

GlobalFoundries intends to use the funding to help pay for the construction of a new advanced chip factory in Malta, New York, increase production at its existing plant in Malta as part of a strategic agreement with General Motors, and revitalize its plant in Burlington, Vermont.

Tourism is foundation of prosperity: Aryal

BY OUR CORRESPONDENT
Butwal, Feb. 19

Chief Secretary of the Federal Government Dr. Baikuntha Aryal has said that tourism is the foundation of the economic prosperity in the country.

Stating that the cable cars built recently in various places of Nepal have been successful in bringing in domestic and foreign tourists, he stressed the need for bringing more Indian tourists to the tourist destinations of Nepal.

Talking to the media after visiting the Lumbini Cable Car in Butwal and the Kamaksha Devi Temple, Chief Secretary Dr. Aryal said that tourism was one of the main foundations of Nepal's economic prosperity and cable cars have, of late, become an attractive destination for domestic and foreign tourists.

He said that if more Indian tourists were attracted to the cable cars built in the hilly areas of Nepal, it would help in economic prosperity.

Dr. Aryal said that as Uttar Pradesh alone has a population of around 240 million and if a small part of that population were brought to the cable cars built in the hilly areas of Nepal every year, it would have a positive impact on the country's economy.

He said that the government was ready to support the marketing of tourist spots developed by the private sector investing huge amounts.

Chief Secretary Dr. Aryal said, "For the citizens of India's Uttar Pradesh, the mountainous region of Nepal and the cable cars built here are new and attractive destinations, so it is necessary to market such destinations throughout India.

The government also supports the campaign carried out by the private sector to publicise the destinations at home and abroad," he said.

On that occasion, operation manager of Lumbini Cable Car Dilli Narayan Kayastha Saiju said that there was a plan to build a star hotel with 150 rooms, 1,000 capacity banquet hall and a casino at the top station of the cable car at a cost of Rs. 3 billion within two years.

He said that the company has been giving one per cent of each ticket price to Butwal Sub-Metropolitan City and Tinahu Rural Municipality as a local tax.

Chief Secretary of Lumbini Province Radhika Aryal said that the province government would support its promotion and marketing as the Lumbini Cable Car is the first cable car in Lumbini Province and would contribute greatly to the promotion of tourism in the province.

On that occasion, a team, including the Chief Minister also inspected the bottom station, Bamghat and the top station, Basantapur of the Lumbini Cable Car.

Japan hosts Ukraine reconstruction



PHOTO: AP

Japan-Ukraine Officials shaking hands after they agreed for the aid.

AP
Tokyo, Feb 19

Japanese Prime Minister Fumio Kishida on Monday pledged his country's long-term engagement in Ukraine's reconstruction, calling it a future investment, as Japan stressed its commitment to supporting the war-torn country ahead of the two-year anniversary of Russia's invasion.

In his keynote speech at a conference Japan co-organized with the Ukrainian government and business organizations, Kishida said Japanese public and private cooperation will be a long-term partnership based on inclusivity, humanitarianism as well as technology and knowledge.

Kishida stressed the importance of investment across industries for the future of that country's development and ensuring that the support caters to Ukraine's needs. More than 50 cooperation deals were signed by Japanese and Ukrainian government agencies and companies, and Kishida announced an opening of a new government trade office in Kyiv.

Among the deals was Japan's pledge of 15.8 billion yen ($105 million) in new aid for Ukraine to fund demining and other urgently needed reconstruction projects in the energy and transportation sectors, the Foreign Ministry said.

Support for Ukraine's reconstruction is about "investing in the future," Kishida said. "The war in Ukraine is still going on at this very moment and the situation is not easy. The promotion of economic reconstruction, however, is not only an investment for the future of Ukraine but also investing in Japan and the whole globe."

Japan hopes to build momentum for global support for Ukraine as the war drags on and attention has diverted to the conflict in Gaza. Japan's focus on reconstruction — in part due to its legal restraints on providing lethal weapons — contrasts with many Western countries, whose largely military support faces increasing scrutiny over costs. A new U.S. aid package to Ukraine is stalled in the Congress.

Ukraine's Prime Minister Denys Shmyhal, who led his country's delegation of more than 100 people, expressed thanks for the encouragement and said that "today is the new start of cooperation between the two countries."

"By combining our powers ... we can change this challenge into an opportunity for future growth and prosperity," he said. "Japan's experiences in reconstruction (from World War II) and its economic miracle provide us with inspiration."

All eyes are on Ukraine, and "dictators and potential invaders" are also turning their eyes to see how Russia's violation of the international law is seen and how the world will react to it.

Shmyhal said Ukraine's reconstruction goes far beyond removal of landmines and debris.

He emphasized his country's strength in farming, rich natural resources and ambition to be a digital hub of Europe with its information and cybersecurity expertise. He also urged Japanese automakers to open factories in Ukraine.

About 300 people and 80 companies were to attend from the two countries, Japanese officials have said.

The Japan-Ukraine Conference for Promotion of Economic Growth and Reconstruction is co-organized by the Japanese and Ukrainian governments, Japan's powerful business organization Keidanren, and Japan External Trade Organization, or JETRO.

In a joint communique, the two sides stated Japan's long-term support in helping Ukraine achieve economic stability.

The two countries also noted the importance of maintaining tough sanctions against Russia. Japan announced the start of talks toward revising a bilateral investment pact and easing of travel restrictions for Japanese business visitors to Ukraine.

The conference is largely about reconstruction and investment in Ukraine, but it's also about Japan's national security.

Japan's $12.1 billion contribution to Ukraine over the past two years is mostly financial and humanitarian as its military equipment provisions are limited to non-lethal weapons, and much smaller compared to $111 billion the United States has provided in weapons, equipment, humanitarian assistance.

Czech farmers protest over EU agriculture policies



AP
Prague, Feb 19

Hundreds of tractors blocked a lane in downtown Prague in a farmers protest Monday over European Union agriculture policies and what they said were unfair practises.

Major organizations representing Czech farmers didn't participate and distanced themselves from the rally after it turned out some organizers were behind recent pro-Russian demonstrations. Traffic was not halted but City Hall warned people not to drive to Prague on Monday.

The protesters were planning to hand Agriculture Minister Marek Vyborny a letter with their demands. They particularly target the EU's Green Deal, which calls for limits on the use of chemicals and on greenhouse gas emissions and want the country out of it. Some demanded the government's resignation.

Other farmers groups said they planned separate demonstrations on Thursday with counterparts from neighboring and other countries.

Similar protests have taken place across the bloc in recent weeks. Farmers complain that the 27-nation EU's policies on the environment and other matters are a financial burden and make their products more expensive than non-EU imports.

The European Commission, the EU's executive arm, has made some concessions over the last few weeks, including shelving plans to halve the use of pesticides and other dangerous substances. Nonetheless, the protests have spread.

International exercise on peacekeeping starts today

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Feb. 19

The Nepali Army has completed all necessary preparations for conducting the 'Exercise Shanti Prayas -IV'. The exercise, which aims to enhance the skills and interoperability among troops contributing countries to the United Nations peacekeeping missions, is scheduled to take place at the Shree Birendra Peace Operation Training Centre (BPOTC) in Panchkhal of Kavre district from February 20 to March 4.

The inaugural session of the exercise, will however, be held at the Army Headquarters, on Tuesday, according to Brigadier General and Spokesperson for the Directorate of Public Relations and Information, Krishna Prasad Bhandari.

The exercise is a collaborative effort between the Nepali Army and the United States government's Global Peace Operation Initiative. The GPOI focuses on fostering excellence in the proficiency of peacekeeping forces, enhancing mutual coordination capabilities and ensuring interoperability among Troops Contributing Countries (TCCs) to the UN.

This marks the fourth iteration of Nepal-hosted Exercise Shanti Prayas, with the first one conducted in 2000. The second and third editions took place in 2013 and 2017. The upcoming exercise, set to commence on Tuesday, will see participation from military personnel representing 19 nations, including Nepal, said Brigadier General Bhandari.

A total of 1,125 participants will engage in various events, including 689 individuals in Field Training Events (FTE), 110 in Staff Training Events (STE) and 326 in Critical Enabler and Capability Enhancement (2CE) activities. The exercise aims not only to address challenges encountered in peacekeeping efforts but also to increase awareness among participating nations about the challenges.

The participating soldiers are expected to develop the necessary skills and adopt a uniform professional approach to overcome these challenges, fostering mutual trust and cooperation in global peacekeeping endeavours, the NA believed.



SC hearing on controversial vehicle facility procedure of NRB on February 26

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Feb. 19

The Supreme Court has invited the top officials of Nepal Rastra Bank for a discussion relating to a case filed against the Rastra Bank, its top officials and the Finance Ministry. The Supreme Court has invited them for February 26 for discussions.

Advocates Kumar Magar and Bharat Karki on February 6 filed a case against the Ministry of Finance, Rastra Bank and its high-level officials demanding certiorari against a procedure introduced by the Nepal Rastra Bank to increase vehicular facilities to the top NRB officials.

The two advocates have demanded the annulment of the Management of the Motor Vehicle Facility Procedure-2078 stating that it contradicted the Clause 110 of the Nepal Rastra Bank Act 2058. They also argued that the Procedure was against the Public Procurement Act-2063 and was introduced with an ill intention as the NRB does not have to inform the public about such procedure.

"They have introduced the procedure with an intention of making the vehicles private after their retirement but laws do not allow them to formulate and implement such procedure," advocate Bharat Karki told The Rising Nepal. The first hearing on the case was held on February 11.

The Procedure has fixed the ceiling of Rs. 18.2 million to buy a motor for the Governor while two Deputy Governors could get up to Rs. 14. 3 million each and 18 Directors Rs. 7.01 million each to purchase their vehicles.

Advocate Karki said that they and the defendants were invited to the discussions. Only after the discussion of February 26, the SC will decide whether or not to issue any interim order in the case.

Two killed, 16 injured in jeep accident in Tanahun

BY AMARRAJ NAHARKI
Tanahun, Feb. 19

Two persons were killed and 16 other passengers, including the driver, sustained injuries in a Bolero jeep accident at Giraunchaur of Abukhaireni Rural Municipality-1, Tanahun.

The accident occurred at 12:30 am on Monday while the jeep with registration number Ba 18 Ch 5921 was carrying a marriage procession from Mirlung to Chhapswara. The jeep met with the accident when the driver lost control, said police.

One of the victims, 72-year-old Ashbir Gurung, lost his life at the accident site, while 17-year-old Tulsi Gurung succumbed to injuries during treatment at New Medical College Bharatpur Chitwan later on Monday early morning at 3:40, according to Deputy Superintendent of Police Mohan Bahadur Khand of District Police Office Tanahun.

Currently, sixteen injured individuals, including the driver, are undergoing treatment in various hospitals.

The injured included Subina Gurung, 15, Man Bahadu Gurung, 67, Sukmaya Gurung, 38, Elisa Gurung, 6, and Sabita Gurung, 19, from Chhapswara in the same ward. Additionally, Sisir Gurung, 10, from Bandipur Rural Municipality-3, Sukhaura, and Rajkumar Bishwakarma, 38, from Abukhaireni Rural Municipality-1, Giraunchaur, suffered injuries.

Other injured individuals are Somlal Gurung, 56, Bhakkulal Gurung, 70, Sher Bahadur Gurung, 56, Asmaya Gurung, 36, Diksha Gurung, 10, Sete Gurung, 52, Chizkumari Gurung, 36, her son Susan Gurung, 18 months, and Sunita Gurung, 37.

DSP Khand said that the injured are receiving treatment at Chitwan Medical College Bharatpur and Ambukhaireni Hospital,Tanahun. The police are currently investigating the causes of the accident.



PHOTO: AMARRAJ NAHARKI/TRN
Pokhara accident

Dolakha to host three-day religious festival on Bhima Ekadashi

BY OUR CORRESPONDENT
Dolakha, Feb. 19

A grand fair is going to be held at Bhimeshwor Temple of Bhimeshwor Municipality-2 in Dolakha district on the day of Bhima Ekadashi. Stalin Shrestha, ward chairperson, said that unlike in the past, a grand fair of Bhima Ekadashi would be held this time.

Bhima Ekadashi used to be marked only for a day in the past, but this year we are going to celebrate it for three days from February 19 to 21 by organising various programmes, Shrestha said.

Cultural expert Dr. Jagman Gurung is scheduled to deliver a speech on the historical and religious significance and unique culture of the ancient city of Dolakha Bazaar on February 19.

Shrestha said that on the day of Bhima Ekadashi on February 20, Rudri Puja and Home Yagya would be performed at Bhimeshwar while Aarti puja would be performed in the evening by lighting lamps and hymns would be song by devotees staying awake throughout the night.

As per mythology, Bhima Ekadashi is celebrated to make the day when merchants who were in debt were relieved from the debt by the grace of lord Mahadev after being satisfied with the worship of Bhimsen.

The festival has been celebrated at Bhimeshwar Temple for centuries, as it is believed that fasting on Bhima Ekadashi will get people rid of their debt. The committee has urged the devotees to offer only Gokul Dhoop, Sal Dhoop or Bateko Dhoop at Bhimeshwar Temple.

It has also been urged not to offer small iron tridents and bells, and puja items. The devotees who have to offer Trishuls and bells will be allowed to offer only the tridents and bells of the sizes prescribed by the committee.

Roosters, he-goats, eggs and raw coconut are not allowed to be offered during Rudri puja.



PHOTO: BABURAM SHARMA/TRN
Bhimeshwor Temple, Dolakha.

Seven new missing border pillars found while repairing pillars in Jhapa

BY BISHNU PRASAD POKHAREL
Damak, Feb. 19

Armed Police Force Nepal No. 2 Battalion Headquarte rs Jhapa has found seven pillars that were missing on the Nepal-India border.

Superintendent of the Armed Police Force Nepal (SP) Devraj Aryal said that the joint team of Nepal and the Indian security officials have found the missing pillars while repairing and colouring the other pillars.

SP Aryal said that for the first time, border repair, maintenance and painting work has been done on the Nepal-India border and seven border pillars have been found during this process. Nepal's side has got responsibility to repair, maintain and colour the pillars having odd digits.

According to him, 317 odd-numbered border pillars have been repaired, maintained and painted so far.

On behalf of India, SSB has carried out maintenance and painting of 148 border pillars. Aryal said that seven additional pillars were found while repairing border pillars.

Jhapa shares 144.02 km of international border with India. According to SP Aryal, during the last one-year, illegal farming done in 37 places in the Dasgaja area has been cleared. Similarly, 12 out of 17 houses have been removed. The remaining five are in the process of being demolished.

Although it is not allowed to build houses in the Dasgaja area of the international border, in some places, citizens of both countries construct houses.

After the transfer of Aryal, Kavindra Rai has been sent there as a new commandant at the Battalion Headquarters and has expressed his commitment to fulfill the assigned responsibilities and illegal activities in the border area.



PHOTO: BISHNU PRASAD POKHAREL/TRN
Security personnel from Nepal and India painting a border pillar in Jhapa.

CLOTH BANK COMES INTO OPERATION IN BUTWAL

BY OUR CORRESPONDENT
Siddharthanagar, Feb. 19

A cloth bank has been established in Butwal. The Cloth and Food Bank Nepal has established the cloth bank in the coordination of Butwal Sub-Metropolitan City.

Superstar of Nepali filmdom Rajesh Hamal, patron of Cloth and Food Bank Nepal, has started the cloth bank by establishing a cloth box for the collection of clothes in Butwal.

After the agreement with the Butwal Sub-Metropolitan City, the cloth bank formally came into operation in Butwal on Saturday.

Khel Raj Pandey, Mayor of Butwal Sub-Metropolitan City, said that the cloth bank was established so that old clothes could be recycled and reused.

Stating that the people have been searching for human development, not just physical development, Mayor, Pandey, said that the Butwal Sub-Metropolitan City has been investing a budget not only for the development of the infrastructure but was also working to enrich the life of the people.

Sabitra Devi Aryal, Deputy-Mayor of Sub-Metropolitan City, urged locals to set up cloth collection centers in different places in Butwal and help in collecting old clothes.

First garden for conservation of indigenous, migratory birds set up

BY SACHIN POKHAREL
Itahari, Feb. 19

An aviary garden has been established on the premises of the Nepali Army barrack, situated near the bustling market area of Itahari, the heart of Koshi Province, aiming to protect both local indigenous and migratory bird species.

The newly built garden serves as a proactive measure to prioritise the protection of the lush tree plantations within the army's barracks area. Additionally, it encompasses around a dozen ponds and wetlands, providing vital habitats for indigenous and migratory bird species originating from various regions, including Siberia.

The garden, crafted with a variety of tree species and plants, has taken shape in the vicinity of the former Division Headquarters of the Nepali Army. Chief of Army Staff Prabhu Ram Sharma inaugurated the garden on Saturday.

Dr. Aasha Bahadur Tamang, the General Officer Commanding of Eastern part, highlighted the importance of the operation of the bird garden. He noted that the garden, situated within the former Divisional Headquarter complex, attracts birds from places like Siberia due to its diverse array of plant species, wetlands, and ponds. This dynamic ecosystem fosters a welcoming environment for both resident and migratory bird populations, underscoring the garden's importance, he added.

According to Tamang, around 15 species of migratory birds from places like Siberia visit the bird habitat garden within the Itahari barrack area annually. Also, around 30 species of resident birds, known as indigenous birds, have made the garden their permanent home.

The environment of eastern Nepal, particularly during the winter months, is considered favourable for visiting birds, akin to those from Siberia seeking refuge to spend the winter and raise their young ones.

In a concerted effort to protect and sustain these avian populations, the bird habitat garden features a rich variety of plant species, including apple, lime, lychee, mango, jackfruit, gooseberry, papaya and other popular plants.

This diverse vegetation serves as essential nesting and foraging grounds, ensuring the well-being and survival of the resident and migratory birds alike, he added.

THOUGHT FOR TODAY

Those who do not remember the past are condemned to repeat it.
- George Santayana

EDITORIAL

For Vibrant Democracy

Democracy is rightly touted as the best form of governance due to its promise and emphasis on individual rights and freedom, ensuring that no one is subjected to the despotic diktats of a ruler. Instead, in democracy people are in a position to call the shots. Globally, people's yearning for such privileges has prompted them to sacrifice or/and risk everything, countless lives included. In Nepal, like elsewhere, democracy has been earned through our martyrs' untold sacrifices and several political movements. The abolishment of monarchy and the subsequent promulgation of constitution in 2015 marks a key milestone in our journey towards democracy. Our constitution has been quite generous and liberal in granting every conceivable fundamental and other rights – from rights heath to food to employment – alongside envisaging a welfare state.

But, despite lofty promises and ideals, it would be fair to state that we have a long way to go in our march towards fulfilling the aspirations of the people as well as the constitutional pledge. Problems in its implementation abound. For one, strong economic foundation to materialise at least a few of them remains a far cry. Fed up with a dire dearth of employment opportunities, youths leaving the country out of desperation in alarming numbers even for countries fraught with grave risks forces us to question whether our democracy has delivered. What promise does it hold when it fails to deliver even the most basic of the necessities? It doesn't mean much.

Second, a flurry of corruption scandals – from gold-smuggling to land grabbing to many financial irregularities – in recent years have continued to misuse the tax payers' money, not to mention deprive the general public of the financial means critical for their lives and livelihoods. When corrupt civil servant abuse public office for private gain, competency of public and social institutions suffers.

Third, particracy, through which politically-affiliated people are appointed in key state organs and government mechanisms in a blatant disregard for meritocracy, also compromises democracy. To get away with this problem, we must be vigilant and vocal to let the culture of meritocracy take hold. Fourth, a lack of strong legal and policy framework, strong leadership, and law enforcement agencies has made it difficult to tackle growing corruption and enhance good governance, one of the pillars of democracy. We must also give credit where it's due: Major decisions have also been done to consolidate democracy.

Today in much of the world, including the so-called matured and advanced democracies, democracy is said to be stagnant at best; and in decline at worst, signaling that democracy is in trouble globally, says a major recent report. This may explain why in many countries the trend of democracy giving way to dictatorship – military or otherwise – that too with surprisingly little resistance is in relentless march. Forget the global south, even in the 'bastions' of democracy like the US and Europe, populism is on the rise, eroding public's faith in democratic institutions and norms.

Everything is not doom and gloom, though. The rise of social media has given voice to the voiceless to make themselves and their grievances heard, empowering the less-privileged and marginalised, enhancing their participation in democratic process and lifting them to the mainstream from the margin. Though it has also been abused to spread disinformation, hate speeches and disrupt communal harmony and weaken democracy, social media's judicious use stands to bode well for democracy overall, outweighing its benefits over risks. For all its vulnerabilities, democracy has no alternative. Guarding it from potential pitfalls is imperative for its robustness and vibrancy.

Mahasamiti Conclave

Will It Bolster Congress's Position?



Narayan Upadhyay

Many Nepali Congress (NC) functionaries and sympathisers have been waiting for the outcome of the highly anticipated Mahasamiti meeting, which began Monday in the picturesque town of Godavari. The three-day meeting of the NC top decision-making body is expected to produce decisions that will not only set the agenda for the country's oldest democratic and largest party in the current parliament, but will also assist the party in bolstering the nation's socioeconomic and political well-being in the coming days. It will assist Congress strengthen its position in ensuring long-term stability, peace, good governance, growth, and prosperity for the country. The conclave must also assist the party in fulfilling its role for institutional growth and federalism and republicanism.

The Mahasamiti meeting, being attended by over 2,100 representatives from across the country, came at a time when the largest party was under fire from various quarters for being plagued by internal strife and failing to devise measures to lift the country out of its current predicament. Many Congress supporters and ordinary citizens believe that conference will help address the pathetic level of political instability, rising corruption, poor law and order, a high rate of unemployment, the exodus of youths to foreign shores, and a failing economy largely based on remittances. Apart from several difficulties facing the party, workers and supporters have chastised the party leadership for playing second fiddle to former rebels in the government while being the largest party in parliament. Attendees in the ongoing conclave are likely to deliberate on these issues and reach conclusions.

Displeasure

Just before the long-awaited conference began, NC officials at the CWC meeting expressed their displeasure with not just three documents to be delivered by vice president Purna Bahadur Khadka, but also two general secretaries, Gagan Thapa and Bishwo Prakash Sharma. The CWC meeting revealed that attendees would make the proposals in the Godavari conclave difficult for the party's top echelon to negotiate.

Many believe that the oldest democratic party, which was at the vanguard of realising, restoring democracy, and leading people's movements to transform the country into a federal republic, is now behaving meekly as a result of coalition politics. NC general secretary Gagan Thapa, who has been tasked with submitting a document on the party's organisational aspects, came out strongly against the party's ideologies and independence being overshadowed by coalition politics.

Thapa rapped party leaders for behaving docilely in front of other coalition partners, arguing that the party should abandon alliance politics and contest all future elections on its own. He even urged that laws prohibiting some parties from contesting elections and creating alliances be implemented immediately. However, general secretary Sharma disputed Thapa, claiming that alliance politics has benefited the NC and the nation by bringing stability to the government, despite internal party divisions. Meanwhile, on the eve of the jamboree, some prominent Congress legislators and leaders pushed the Hindu narrative by launching a larger pro-Hindu campaign. Before the meeting began, they delivered a memorandum to the party president, urging to incorporate a Hindu agenda in the party's statute, which would require the party to strive for the nation's reversion to a Hindu state.

> Many Congress supporters want the attendees and party leadership to focus on resolving disputes, mistrust, ideological ambiguity within the party, and other gaping issues.

The NC, however, is unlikely to respond positively to this appeal because the coalition partners — the CPN-Maoist Centre and others — as well as the main opposition party, all signatories, and important players in the current constitution do not support it at this time. It is said that a few Congressmen have succumbed to the sway of various interest groups and pro-Hindu elements, who have increased their pressure. It would be interesting if the conclave took up and debated the subject.

There are suggestions that the party reconsider the current electoral system, which prevents any party from becoming the overall winner and forming its own government. Because the provision of electing 40 per cent of legislators through the proportional representation system is linked to hung parliaments, this election system should be changed. No one other than senior leader Shekhar Koirala and his supporters expressed displeasure about such a system and requested that Congress work hard to amend or modify it for the benefit of the multi-party parliamentary system.

Having said that, it is commonly assumed that NC president Sher Bahadur Deuba and his close allies in the party will avoid any requests or proposals that will irritate both coalition partners and the main opposition party. As a result, the party may remain firm in its stance on secularism and the federal republican fabric. Meanwhile, the Congress must deal with the communists' political dominance. Two communist parties — the CPN-UML and the CPN Maoist Centre — have posed significant threats to the party. The party leadership's choice to form and remain in the ruling coalition has allowed the party to maintain its position at the forefront of national politics. The NC will suffer if and when the communists get together to form a unified front. So, General Secretary Thapa's comments and insistence that the NC abandon coalition politics appear ill-advised at the moment.

Cooperation

The cooperation with the Maoist Centre and Janata Samajbadi Party, among others, has kept communists separate, which has benefited the Congress. Thapa nonetheless should be commended for providing certain action plans in his document aimed at organising and improving the political and governance structures. He has advocated that the president be limited to one term, the prime minister to two, the minister to three, and the member of parliament to four. When the same person continues to be the party's leader and is repeatedly assigned major state tasks, other capable members are denied the opportunity, causing bitterness towards the party, political system, and governance system.

Finally, many Congress supporters want the attendees and party leadership to focus on resolving disputes, mistrust, ideological ambiguity within the party, and other gaping issues. They believe that the conclave will succeed in bringing the party together and providing clear guidelines and a future roadmap.

(Upadhyay is former managing editor of this daily.)

Need To Streamline Public Holidays



Uttam Maharjan

The government has recently announced public holidays for the year 2081. As per the announcement, there will be 35 public holidays in the coming year. With 52 Saturdays, the number of holidays will be 87. There is a practice of announcing public holidays by publishing the list of such holidays in the Gazette. Additional holidays may, however, be added though Cabinet decisions.

Last year, the government declared Falgun 1 as a public holiday in commemoration of the start of the Maoist insurgency on Falgun 1, 2052. The day is celebrated as People's War Day by Maoists and others. However, the government had to scrap the holiday because the Supreme Court had annulled the holiday. When the public holiday was announced last year, many people, including the victims of the Maoist insurgency and human rights activists, were not happy. Their sentiments were badly hurt. During the Maoist insurgency, over 17,000 people were killed and many more were wounded. Further, many people were made to disappear.

Limbo

The Truth and Reconciliation Commission (TRC) and the Commission of Investigation on Enforced Disappeared Persons (CIEDP) are almost in limbo. That is why the peace process, which began in 2006, has not been fully completed yet. The victims of the Maoist insurgency and other people got elated at the decision of the Supreme Court that annulled the public holiday on Falgun 1, while the Maoists got offended. It is an irony that the government had to backtrack on giving a public holiday on the said day when Maoist Supremo Pushpa Kamal Dahal 'Prachanda' is the Prime Minister.

Public holidays consist of festive holidays, special day holidays and birth anniversary holidays. As announced by the government, the list of public holidays for 2081 include 27 festive days, six special day holidays and two birth anniversary holidays. With the abolition of the Panchayat system in the early 1990s, the successive governments have added a number of public holidays to the national calendar.

It is said that Nepal has too many public holidays. World Statistics, an organisation that keeps global data, published the list of 48 countries with the highest number of public holidays some months ago. As per the data, Nepal topped the list with 35 public holidays, followed by Myanmar (32 holidays), Iran (26 holidays), Sri Lanka (25 holidays) and Bangladesh and Egypt (22 holidays each). India was in eighth position with 21 public holidays, with Pakistan in 16th position with 16 holidays. The statistics did not include weekly holidays.

When there are too many public holidays, it hampers the public service delivery system. It creates hassles for service-seekers, especially those from remote areas who have to visit Kathmandu. They have to manage lodging, food and time. They have to spend more to avail themselves of public services. It is these and other people who are constantly complaining that there are too many public holidays. In fact, having too many public holidays has an adverse impact on the efficiency and timeliness of service delivery and affects good governance. One of the yardsticks of gauging good governance is effective public service delivery.

> Unnecessary public holidays need to be retrenched so as to boost economic productivity by making the public service delivery mechanism efficient and effective.

The successive governments themselves admit that the country has too many public holidays. They have formed several holiday revision committees but the recommendations made by such committees are hardly implemented. In 2018, the Oli-led government decided to reduce public holidays by 15 days for prompt public service delivery and to maintain good governance. But the government backtracked on its decision two years later.

At a time when there were voices against too many public holidays, the government declared two days of holiday a week (Saturday and Sunday) on May 15, 2022. The main thrust of the arrangement was to reduce the consumption of fuel. But the arrangement was scrapped with effect from June 15, 2022. Such an exercise had also been made two decades before with the aim of boosting the efficiency and productivity of civil servants. But the intended goals could not be achieved and the provision was scrapped within a few months. Public holidays are added to the national calendar based on the government's decision. The government may announce public holidays suddenly as on visits by heads of state from foreign countries or on the death of prominent figures. This may also hamper public service delivery, inconveniencing service-seekers.

Contravention

It seems the government is not inclined to reduce public holidays. There are many ethnic groups in the country. The government has seemingly announced public holidays for particular ethnic groups so as to please them and use them as a vote bank. Furthermore, provincial or local governments tend to announce public holidays on their own in contravention of the national holiday calendar approved by the federal government. Announcing public holidays haphazardly is not a good thing. There should be some sort of uniformity in public holidays.

It follows that a proper study is needed to systematise public holidays in the country. Unnecessary public holidays need to be curtailed. For example, there is no need for a public holiday on Christmas Day in the country. It is a bit surprising that there is a public holiday on December 25 (Christmas Day) but not on January 1 (Christian New Year). As the country is economically poor, there is a need to boost and improve the economy. Therefore, unnecessary public holidays need to be retrenched so as to boost economic productivity by making the public service delivery mechanism efficient and effective.

(Maharjan has been regularly writing on contemporary issues for this daily since 2000.)

Black Phosphorus Kills Deadly Bacterial Cells

PETER DERYABIN

Researchers have developed a nanothin material that can kill superbugs, and the material has great potential for future integration into medical dressings and implants to prevent or treat bacterial infections.

This innovative technology, which has undergone extensive preclinical testing, demonstrates its effectiveness against a variety of bacterial species, including superbugs such as Staphylococcus aureus, which are typically highly resistant to antibiotics. Antibiotic resistance is a serious global health threat, causing about 700,000 deaths annually, a figure that could rise to 10 million deaths per year by 2050 unless new methods are developed to combat bacterial infections.

The latest research, conducted jointly by RMIT University and the University of South Australia (UniSA), focuses on nanotechnology using black phosphorus as an advanced treatment for infections and wounds. The results, published in the journal Advanced Therapeutics, demonstrate the high effectiveness of this technology in treating infections. It is capable of killing more than 99 per cent of bacteria while leaving other cells intact in biological models.

It should be noted that the effectiveness of this treatment is comparable to the results achieved with antibiotics in terms of eliminating the infection and accelerating the healing process. For example, in experiments, wounds healed 80 per cent in seven days. This world-class nanotechnology developed by RMIT has been subjected to rigorous pre-clinical testing by wound healing specialists at UniSA. In addition, RMIT University has applied for patent protection for the black phosphorus-based material, including its use in wound healing formulations such as gels.

Professor Sumit Walia, research leader at RMIT University, said their new research sheds light on the way their innovative technology provides rapid antimicrobial action and then safely degrades once the threat of contamination has been eliminated. He explained: "What makes our innovation unique is that it is not just a surface coating. It can be integrated into common materials such as cotton and titanium used to create medical dressings and implants, as well as plastics and gels, making them durable to microbes."

Previous research at RMIT University has already shown that black phosphorus is effective in killing microorganisms when it is applied in nano-thin layers on the surface of materials used to create medical dressings, implants (such as titanium), and in plastics used in medical applications.

Black phosphorus is the most stable form of phosphorus and is found naturally in many foods. In its ultra-thin form, this material easily degrades when exposed to oxygen, making it ideal for killing germs. "As a nanomaterial degrades, its surface interacts with the atmosphere, which leads to the formation of reactive oxygen species. These reactive oxygen species ultimately help break the bacterial cells apart."

The new study tested the effectiveness of nanofine black phosphorus flakes against five common strains of bacteria, including E. coli and drug-resistant Staphylococcus aureus. "Our antimicrobial nanotechnology quickly and effectively killed more than 99 of bacterial cells, which significantly exceeds the results of traditional methods of treating infections used today," said Professor Walia.

- Pravda.ru

50 YEARS AGO

THE RISING NEPAL

February 20, 1974

School Building

A primary school building has been constructed in Bihabart village Kavre of district through voluntary labour of the local people, reports RSS

NOTICE TO CONTRIBUTORS

TRN welcomes articles, letters and comments from our valued readers and contributors.
Please email your contributions to:

trnfeatures@hotmail.com
trnfeatures@gmail.com

Or send them to
P.O. Box 23, Kathmandu, Nepal

READER'S MAIL

Promote Agro Sector To Create Jobs



This refers to a news report *'Policy reforms needed for development of agriculture sector: President Paudel,'* published in the digital edition of this daily the other day. As per the report, President Ramchandra Paudel has pointed out the need of policy reforms in the agriculture sector.

The President made this remark while inaugurating the 'Extensive Kavrepalanchok Agriculture Festival-2024' in Banepa. The President's remarks hold water but the challenges lie in commercialising the agriculture sector so that the youths seeking to go abroad for better job prospect stay at home to boost the agro production.

It is imperative to unveil special programmes for increasing the exports and import substitution through production and employment growth. The agriculture and animal husbandry have a huge potential in transforming the life of peasants. For this, skills, knowledge and technology related to this has to be transferred the new generation.

Kavrepalanchok district is known for its feat in agriculture, dairy and market-oriented agriculture produce. Other districts should also emulate its achievements to make agro sector lucrative and viable means of livelihoods.

Ramhari Kharel
Banepa

TAILPIECE

A grandmother who took her little grandson to the beach. They were having a good time until a huge wave came in and swept the boy out to sea. She fell down on her knees and pleaded to the heavens, "Please return my grandson, that's all I ask! PLEASE!!!"

A moment later, lo and behold, a wave swelled from the ocean and deposited the wet, yet unhurt child, at her feet. She checked him over to make sure that he was okay. He was fine. But still she looked up to the heavens angrily and said, "When we came he had a hat!"

+++++

Little Johnny was eating breakfast one morning and got to thinking about things.

"Mommy, why has daddy got so few hairs on his head?" he asked his mother.

"He thinks a lot," replied his mother, pleased with herself for coming up with a good answer to her husband's baldness.

Johnny thought for a second and said, "I'm glad you don't do any thinking. You would look silly without hair."

Tribal violence in Papua New Guinea kills 26 combatants

AP
Australia, Feb. 19

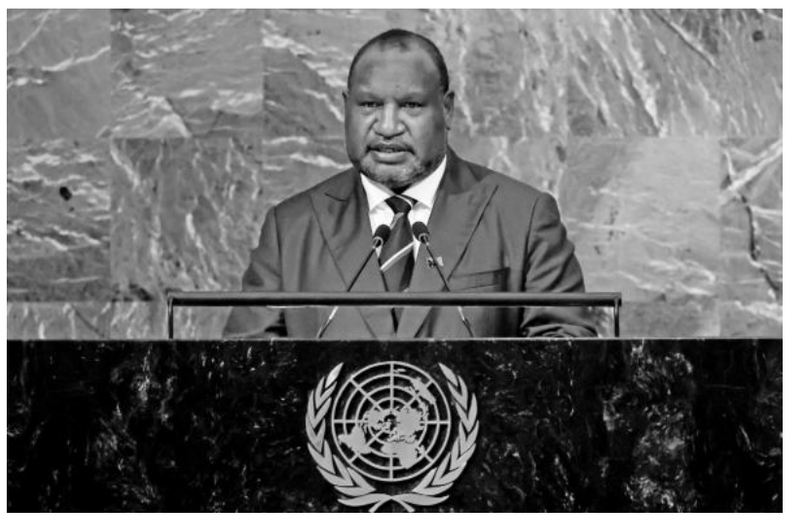


PHOTO: AP

Prime Minister of Papua New Guinea James Marape addresses the 77th session of the United Nations General Assembly, Sept. 22, 2022, at U.N. headquarters.

At least 26 combatants and an unconfirmed number of bystanders were killed in a gunbattle between warring tribes in Papua New Guinea, police said Monday.

A tribe, their allies and mercenaries were on their way to attack a neighboring tribe when they were ambushed Sunday in Enga province in the South Pacific nation's remote highlands, Royal Papua New Guinea Constabulary Acting Superintendent George Kakas said.

Police Commissioner David Manning later described the clash as a "gunbattle between warring tribes." An unconfirmed number of villagers also were killed. Police reinforcements were sent to the scene of the battle, Manning said.

"At this point, it's not clear exactly how far we have moved into the conflict there," Manning told Australian Broadcasting Corp. "But the intent is to regain control or have a significant presence in that conflict area and then work ... our way through our procedures in dealing with this type of incident."

Kakas initially said 53 combatants had died. But security forces later revised the death toll down to 26.

Bodies were collected from the battlefield, roads and the riverside, then loaded onto police trucks and taken to the hospital. Authorities were still counting "those who were shot, injured and ran off into the bushes," Kakas said.

Papua New Guinea Prime Minister James Marape said he had "great concern" about the violence in Enga and urged the warring tribes to lay down their weapons.

"If there are community disputes, there are ways to deal with the community disputes," Marape said.

John Luther, a leader of Akom village whose warriors were among those ambushed, talked down the prospect of an escalation of the violence in retaliation for the deaths.

"We've lost a lot of lives. I don't feel we should be able be to retaliate. We're already weak in numbers," Luther told the AP.

The villagers were ambushed from a school building while on a mission to avenge the death of a woman killed in a neighboring allied village, he said.

Luther also accused the military of aiding and arming his enemies in the ambush. He had been told the death toll was 44.

But Papua New Guinea government lawyer Oliver Nobetau said he expects more lives will be lost in retaliatory violence.

"There's a big concern that this will continue on. Revenge killings tend to be a normal thing that happens," said Nobetau, who is on temporary assignment to the Sydney-based international policy think tank Lowy Institute.

He said although tribal violence is common, it has never happened on this scale and that police have limited resources to cope.

"Tribal violence is something that is prevalent and the government with its limited resources will try to deploy the police wherever they can to try to curb the security issues," he said.

Papua New Guinea is a diverse nation of 10 million mostly subsistence farmers speaking 800 languages. Internal security has become an increasing challenge for its government as China, the United States and Australia seek closer security ties to the country in a strategically important part of the South Pacific.

Australian Prime Minister Anthony Albanese said his government was ready to assist Papua New Guinea, which is Australia's nearest neighbor and the largest single recipient of Australian foreign aid.

Tribal violence in the Enga region has intensified since elections in 2022 that maintained Prime Minister James Marape's administration. Elections and accompanying allegations of cheating and process anomalies have always triggered violence throughout the country.

Enga Gov. Peter Ipatas said there were warnings that tribal fighting was about to erupt.

"From a provincial perspective, we knew this fight was going to be on and we (alerted) the security forces last week to make sure they took appropriate action to ensure this didn't occur," Ipatas said.

Scores of people have died in tribal fighting in the Enga region in the past year.

Port Moresby's Post-Courier newspaper has reported that high-powered firearms used in the recent fighting made it risky for police to enter the battlefields.

Police said they were assisted by the military in protecting the general public and government property.

Tens of thousands rally against Mexico's president and ruling party



PHOTO: AP

People take part in a march organised by citizen organisations demanding that electoral autonomy be respected in the upcoming general elections in downtown Mexico City, Sunday, Feb. 18, 2024.

AP
Mexico City, Feb. 19

Tens of thousands of demonstrators cloaked in pink marched through cities in Mexico and abroad on Sunday in what they called a "march for democracy" targeting the country's ruling party in advance of the country's June 2 elections.

The demonstrations called by Mexico's opposition parties advocated for free and fair elections in the Latin American nation and railed against corruption the same day presidential front-runner Claudia Sheinbaum registered as a candidate for ruling party Morena. Approximately 90,000 people turned out to rail against the leader, according to government figures.

Sheinbaum is largely seen as a continuation candidate of Mexico's popular populist leader Andrés Manuel López Obrador. He's adored by many voters who say he bucked the country's elite parties from power in 2018 and represents the working class.

But the 70-year-old president has also been accused of making moves that endanger the country's democracy. Last year, the leader slashed funding for the country's electoral agency, the National Electoral Institute, and weakened oversight of campaign spending, something INE's head said could "wind up poisoning democracy itself." The agency's colour, pink, has been used as a symbol by demonstrators.

López Obrador has also attacked journalists in hours-long press briefings, has frequently attacked Mexico's judiciary and claimed judges are part of a conservative conspiracy against his administration.

In Mexico City on Sunday, thousands of people dressed in pink flocked to the the city's main plaza roaring "get López out." Others carried signs reading "the power of the people is greater than the people in power."

Navalny's widow to attend EU foreign affairs council



PHOTO: AFP

Yulia Navalnaya, wife of late Russian opposition leader Alexei Navalny, attends the Munich Security Conference (MSC), on the day Alexei Navalny's death was announced, on February 16, 2024.

AFP
Russia, Feb. 19

Yulia Navalnaya, the wife of Kremlin critic Alexei Navalny who died in Russian custody, will attend the EU foreign affairs council Monday, the bloc's foreign policy chief Josep Borrell said on Sunday, as Russian courts jailed dozens of people detained at events commemorating his husband.

For many years, Navalnaya insisted she had no interest in getting into politics, but since Navalny's death on Friday, she appears to have turned into her late husband's torchbearer.

EU foreign policy chief Josep Borrell said he would welcome Yulia Navalnaya to the bloc's Foreign Affairs Council on Monday.

"On Monday, I will welcome Yulia Navalnaya at the EU Foreign Affairs Council. EU Ministers will send a strong message of support to freedom fighters in Russia and honour the memory of Alexi @navalny," Borrell said in a statement on X.

The meeting will take place as Russian authorities are still preventing his relatives from seeing the body, three days after his death.

"Alexei's mother and his lawyers arrived at the morgue early in the morning.

They were not allowed to go in. One of the lawyers was literally pushed out. When the staff was asked if Alexei's body was there, they did not answer," Navalny's spokeswoman Kira Yarmysh said on social media.

The announcement came days after Navalnaya electrified an audience of leaders, diplomats and officials at the Munich Security Council when she delivered an impromptu address on Friday just hours after reports of Alexei Navalny's death emerged.

Russia crushes last Avdiivka resistance pocket

AP
Kyiv, Ukraine, Feb. 19

Russian forces have completed their takeover of Avdiivka by eliminating the last pocket of resistance at the eastern Ukraine city's huge coke plant, the Russian military said Monday, after the sheer weight of its troop numbers and greater firepower drove out Kyiv's forces.

Moscow officials announced Saturday said they had taken control of Avdiivka. Ukrainian forces confirmed pulling out of the bombed-out city in what amounted to a triumph for the Kremlin even though the four-month battle was costly.

The victory was a morale boost for Russia, days ahead of the two-year anniversary of its full-scale invasion of its neighbor on Feb. 24 2022. For Ukraine, the loss underscored its reliance on the supply of Western weapons and ammunition, as hold-ups have left it short of provisions and handicapped in the fight.

However, some Western military analysts believe that Ukraine could counter Russia's attempt to build up on its Avdiivka success by trying to erect new defense lines in that immediate area and deploying fresh units to hold back Kremlin's forces.



PHOTO: AP

This photo shows an aerial view of the Avdiivka Coke and Chemical Plant, eastern Ukraine.

Even so, the threat of ammunition shortages hangs over Ukraine's military, with Russia aiming to exploit the moment as the United States struggles to get political agreement for more aid and Europe strives to increase production.

Apart from Avdiivka, Russia is pushing harder in the northeastern Kharkiv region and in southern Zaporizhia, the Washington-based think tank said.

Ukraine President Volodymyr Zelenskyy said his country "is "doing everything possible and impossible" to defeat Russia.

PRISM

Mysterious loose bovine dubbed 'Thundercow'

Oklahoma: Residents near an Oklahoma lake have reported numerous encounters with a mysterious creature -- a loose cow that has been wandering the area for more than a year.

Locals living near Lake Thunderbird in Norman said the bovine, dubbed "Thundercow" by fans on social media, often is seen grazing next to the water during the day, but at night the cow has been known to wander through their neighborhoods.

Resident Natalie Bevill had an encounter with Thundercow in December. "She just sort of popped out of nowhere. It startled us because it's a loose cow and it's pitch-black outside," Bevill told KOCO-TV.

10,568 pieces of memorabilia collected

California: A California man's collection of 10,568 pieces of Transformers memorabilia earned him a Guinness World Records title.

Mike Kaye, who has been collecting robots in disguise since 1984, took the record for the largest collection of Transformers memorabilia from AJ Ard, whose collection was tallied at 5,150 unique items. Kaye said his love of the toy line began when he was about 3 or 4 years old in 1984.

"My family and I were in Sears, and they had a huge selection of Generation 1 Transformers toys," Kaye told Guinness World Records.

(AP)

FDA expands Xolair use to treat severe food allergies

AP
New York, Feb. 19



FILE PHOTO- AP

This Feb. 20, 2015 photo shows an arrangement of peanuts in New York. Xolair, the brand name for the drug omalizumab, used to treat asthma can now be used to help people with food allergies avoid severe reactions, the U.S. Food and Drug Administration said on Friday, Feb. 16, 2024.

A medication used to treat asthma can now be used to help people with food allergies avoid severe reactions, the U.S. Food and Drug Administration said Friday.

Xolair, the brand name for the drug omalizumab, became the first medication approved to reduce allergic reactions caused by accidental exposure to food triggers. Patients as young as age 1 with allergies can take the drug by injection every two to four weeks, depending on their weight and their body's response to allergens.

An estimated 17 million people in the U.S. have the type of food allergies that can cause rapid, serious symptoms, including severe, whole-body reactions that are potentially deadly.

People who use Xolair must continue to avoid the foods that cause them reactions, such as peanuts, cashews, hazelnuts, walnuts, milk products and eggs. The medication allows them to tolerate higher amounts of such foods without causing major reactions.

Many people with allergies — and their families — live with constant anxiety about exposure to allergens and often avoid dining out and other social situations. "To have this protection is going to be life-changing," said Dr. Robert Wood, director of the pediatric allergy division at Johns Hopkins Children's Center.

The FDA decision is based on a study led by Wood and funded by the National Institutes of Health. It showed that Xolair allowed about 68% of participants with peanut allergies to tolerate about 600 milligrams, or about 1/2 teaspoon, of peanut protein, compared with about 6% of those who received dummy injections.

The results were similar for other allergens such as tree nuts, milk, egg and wheat, a study abstract reported. Full results are expected to be presented at a meeting and published in a peer-reviewed journal later this month.

Wood estimated that 25% to 50% of people with food allergies, particularly children and young adults, would elect to use Xolair.

The drug has been used "off-label" to treat food allergies, said Dr. Ruchi Gupta, director of the Center for Food Allergy & Asthma Research at Northwestern University. She welcomed full approval of the product.

Xolair is a monoclonal antibody, a type of treatment that works by blocking the body's natural response to allergens. It was first approved in 2003 and has been used to treat asthma, nasal polyps and chronic hives. It is produced by drugmakers Novartis and Roche and is distributed by a Roche subsidiary, Genentech.

The most common side effects of Xolair are injection site reactions and fever, but the FDA noted that the drug has also been associated with joint pain, rash, parasitic infections, malignancies and abnormal laboratory tests. Xolair comes with a warning saying the treatment itself can cause anaphylaxis and must be started in a health care setting equipped to manage the reaction.

The medication is not approved for emergency treatment of allergic reactions.

The list price for Xolair ranges from about $2,900 a month for children to $5,000 a month for adults, according to Genentech. Most insured patients typically pay less out of pocket, the company said.

TODAY IN HISTORY

1547 – Edward VI of England is crowned King of England at Westminster Abbey.
1835 – The 1835 Concepción earthquake destroys Concepción, Chile.
1872 – The Metropolitan Museum of Art opens in New York City.
1920 – An earthquake kills between 114 and 130 in Georgia and heavily damages the town of Gori.
1956 – The United States Merchant Marine Academy becomes a permanent Service Academy.
2015 – Two trains collide in the Swiss town of Rafz resulting in as many as 49 people injured and Swiss Federal Railways cancelling some services.
2016 – Six people are killed and two injured in multiple shooting incidents in Kalamazoo County, Michigan.
2005 – Spain becomes the first country to vote in a referendum on ratification of the proposed Constitution of the European Union, passing it by a substantial margin, but on a low turnout.



PHOTO: RSS

A carpenter carving wood at Sundarharaincha Municipality in Morang district.

Education Bill will be passed with amendments: PM

RSS
Kathmandu, Feb. 19

Prime Minister Pushpa Kamal Dahal 'Prachanda' has said that the School Education Bill under consideration in the Federal Parliament will passed following necessary amendments.

Speaking at a workshop on 'Nepal's Educational Movement and School Education Bill' organised by the Samajbadi Educational Forum on Monday, the Prime Minister said that the Bill will be further enriched with amendments.

Stating the bill was discussed with the ruling coalition partners and the opposition parties, Prime Minister Prachanda said that the bill will be amended based on the amendment proposals registered in the parliament. "Necessary amendments to the Bill will be made by including the feedback of teachers, trade unions, academicians, students' organisations, stakeholders and the parents," he said.

He also said the government is committed to implementing the agreements made by the state in the past with teachers' associations and other stakeholders.

The Prime Minister called for developing a positive narrative that it is possible to do something in the country, and thereby to prevent the brain drain, for which he emphasized on producing competitive and quality human resources.

Noting that the basis to achieve qualitative progress in the development of quality, competitive, innovation-oriented education should be developed, the Prime Minister said that emphasis has been placed on reward and punishment, along with meritocracy in order to bring about qualitative improvement in the educational sector., "Appointments will be made on the basis of meritocracy in academic institutions, including universities, and that reward and punishment will be enforced the education sector.

On the occasion, CPN (Unified Socialist) Vice President Rajendra Pandey said that the forum should focus its debate on socialism-oriented education.

STUDENTS IN MORANG HAVE TO WALK FOR TWO HOURS TO REACH SCHOOL

BY HARI PRASAD KOIRALA
Urlabari, Feb. 19

Morang district is assumed as one of the most developed districts of the Tarai region. Biratnagar of this district is now the capital of Koshi Province.

However, it may come as a surprise that despite being one of the most developed districts, children in some parts of the district are compelled to embark on a two-hour walk to and from school every day.

Children from Dahar and Bhakare in Kerabari-4 and 5 in the district have to embark on a two-hour journey on foot to reach the nearest community school in their village. Five graders Isa, Puskal, and Nischal Magar as well as three graders Bibek and Bishan Magar reach school walking on foot for three hours every day.

Bimala Magar from Bhakare, currently studying in grade 6, said it takes her two and a half hours to reach the school. It's a very long journey for a child like her, but she said that she reaches school on time almost every day.

Dil Kumari Magar from Dahar in Kerabari-4 said, "Seven of us encounter the Hurhure and Budhi rivers along the way, and there is no bridge over the rivers and it's very risky to cross the river in the rainy season, but we do not have any option."

"We return home without attending school when the river is flooded," said Magar. Kumar Bahadur Bishwakarma, a teacher at Janseba Primary School, said, "Being situated in a hilly village, a little hardship is inevitable."

WSF concludes by issuing 60 declarations

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Feb. 19

The 16th edition of the World Social Forum (WSF) 2024 concluded in Kathmandu on Monday by issuing 60 declarations from organisations worldwide and reaffirming their commitment to building a fairer and more just world.

The Forum started in Brikutimandap with the theme "Another World Is Possible," on February 15. Representatives from various sectors including climate change activists, workers, farmers, trade unions, women's organisations, LGBTQI groups, indigenous communities, ethnic organisations, civil society groups and social movements participated in the five-day event.

The WSF, originating from civil society movements against globalisation in the late 1990s, held its inaugural event in Porto Alegre, Brazil, in 2001. The journey to WSF 2024 in Kathmandu began in November 2022 when Nepal was selected as the potential host country for the 16th edition. The International Council (IC) and the Asia-Pacific Social Forum (APSF) led the selection process, according to a press statement issued by the Nepal Organising Committee on Monday.

March 2023 saw Nepal being officially designated as the host nation, with Kathmandu chosen as the host city. Subsequently, a general council, organising committee and various subcommittees were formed in Nepal, with members volunteering their efforts to ensure the success of WSF 2024, the statement read.

The event witnessed a staggering turnout of over 50,000 participants from 98 nations and six continents, including a concurrent Intercontinental Youth Forum with 410 participants from over 30 countries. More than 400 activities, spanning thirteen diverse themes, were registered for the event, reflecting the multifaceted nature of discussions.

Sushil BK, a member of the Media Coordination Sub-committee, said in a press statement that throughout the event, individuals and groups affected by the current global order, including various social movements, workers, farmers, youth, women, Dalits, tribals, Madhesi, people with disabilities and civil society organisations convened for meetings, conferences, and discourses participated in the forum.

The outcomes of the discussions have been compiled into a comprehensive manifesto, encompassing more than 60 announcements accessible through the WSF website. He expressed gratitude for the extensive coverage of WSF activities thus far, the organisers emphasised the importance of proper coverage of the declaration and other pertinent issues during the closing programme.

As WSF 2024 draws to a close, the manifesto stands as a testament to the collective efforts and aspirations of diverse communities striving for a more just and equitable world, he added.

TWO KILLED IN TIPPER ACCIDENT

RSS
Rampur (Palpa), Feb. 19

Two persons – driver and assistant driver died on the spot in a tipper accident at Arthokgha Rahabas of Mathagadhi rural municipality-5 along the Rahabas Khaireni road section in Palpa district today.

The accident took place when a tipper (Lu 2 Kha 561) en route to Mathagadhi rural municipality-5, Dhamika from Khaireni of Rupandehi district, according to the District Police Office (DPO), Palpa.

The deceased have been identified as Pradeep Kumal, 24, of Tilottama municipality-16 and Manish Pariyar, 18, from the same place. Kumal was the driver while Pariyar was the assistant driver of the tipper, said Superintendent of Police (SP) Suganda Shrestha at the DPO, Palpa. The cause of the accident could not be ascertained yet, said police.

'29,000 Palestinians killed in Israel-Hamas war'

AP
Rafah, Feb. 19

More than 29,000 Palestinians have been killed in the Gaza Strip since the start of the Israel-Hamas war, the territory's Health Ministry said Monday, marking another grim milestone in the deadliest round of violence in the history of the Israeli-Palestinian conflict.

Israeli Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu has vowed to continue the offensive until "total victory" against Hamas, raising fears that troops will soon move into the southernmost town of Rafah on the Egyptian border, where over half of Gaza's 2.3 million people have sought refuge from fighting elsewhere.

The United States, Israel's top ally, says it is still working with mediators Egypt and Qatar to try to broker another cease-fire and hostage release agreement. But those efforts appear to have stalled in recent days, and Netanyahu angered Qatar, which has hosted Hamas leaders, bycalling on it to pressure the militant group.



PHOTO: AP

Palestinian crowds struggle to buy bread from a bakery in Rafah, Gaza Strip, Sunday, Feb. 18.

The Health Ministry said 107 bodies were brought to hospitals in the last 24 hours. That brings the total number of fatalities to 29,092 since the start of the war. The ministry does not distinguish between civilians and combatants in its records, but says around two-thirds of those killed were women and children. More than 69,000 Palestinians have been wounded, overwhelming the territory's hospitals, less than half of which are even partially functioning.

The Health Ministry is part of the Hamas-run government in Gaza but maintains detailed records of casualties. Its figures from previous wars in Gaza have largely matched those of U.N. agencies, independent experts and even Israel's own tallies. The war began when Hamas-led militants stormed into southern Israel from Gaza on Oct. 7, killing some 1,200 people, mostly civilians, and taking around 250 hostage.

More than 100 captives were released during a weeklong cease-fire in November in exchange for 240 Palestinians imprisoned by Israel. Militants still hold around 130, a fourth of them believed to be dead.

Israel responded to the attack by launching one of the deadliest and most destructive military campaigns in recent history on the besieged enclave, which has been ruled by Hamas since 2007.

JSP CALLS CEC MEETING ON FEB 22

RSS
Kathmandu, Feb. 19

The Janata Samajbadi Party (JSP) Nepal has summoned its central executive committee (CEC) meeting for 11:00 am on February 22.

According to party's publicity and publication department chief, Purna Basnet, the meeting has been called as preparations for the party's upcoming National General Convention.

The meeting is scheduled to discuss about the allocation of responsibilities among the central leaders in view of the mega event.

Victims urge...

the necessity of consulting victim communities throughout the legislative process, and victims' active involvement in the establishment of trust commissions.

During the meeting, victims expressed frustration over prolonged injustice and stressed the importance of promptly addressing truth, reparation, social respect, and justice issues.

Organisations of victims including Nepal National Network of Victims of Serious Human Rights Violations, Nepal National Organisation of Women Victims of Conflict Rape, National Memory Network Nepal, Disappeared Family National Network Nepal, Conflict Victims National Network Nepal, Conflict Victims Committee (CVC) and others had gathered for the conference.

The victims' organisations strongly appealed to government entities, political parties, and the parliament to advance the Transitional Justice Act without further delay, acknowledging the pain, anger, and patience of common victims.

According to Bhandari, Prime Minister Prachanda expressed his commitment to conclude the transitional justice process as soon as possible. He also stated that the other political leaders are also convinced to resolve the issue as soon as possible.

NC's Mahasamiti meeting...

The justification for the continuation of the current coalition lies in our political responsibility to safeguard the constitution, ensuring its protection and steadfast implementation," added Deuba.

Similarly, Dhanraj Gurung, Minister for Law, Justice and Parliamentary Affairs and NC Vice President asserted the need to investigate the assets of ward chairmen and ministers. Emphasising the potential for Congress to lead in upcoming elections by winning people's trust, Gurung proposed passing a resolution by the Mahasamiti meeting to scrutinise the properties of ward chairmen and ministers.

"Let's pass the proposal to investigate the assets of the ward chairmen and even the ministers through this meeting," said Gurung, citing concerns over economic governance being compromised due to inroads of capitalism.

He expressed his belief that the influence of crony capitalism, evident in Nepali politics, has also impacted the Nepali Congress, hindering its ability to pursue the right path.

He called for unity within the Mahasamiti members against this phenomenon, urging a balanced policy that considers both the grassroots and the leadership. He proposed a comprehensive discussion in the ongoing meeting about addressing disparities between those at the bottom and the top.

Over 2,000 representatives including 1,780 Mahasamiti members elected from 165 Federal Parliament constituencies are participating in the meeting. However, on the opening ceremony, about 4,000 NC leaders and workers were present on Monday.

Formulation of media-related laws...

Minister Sharma also claimed that the government was trying to bring the nation together in transforming people's lives with a focus on good governance, social justice and prosperity. She shared the determination of the government to support investigations into corruption scams including fake Bhutanese refugees, Lalita Niwas case and gold smuggling.

On the occasion, she said that RSS should be able to compete with other news agencies of the world not only within the country but also internationally by emphasising on the production of quality content. For this required support and facilitation will be provided by the ministry, she added.

"I want to assure of necessary support from the government in the management of the training as well as the necessary resources to make RSS more reliable and effective, with a priority to the audio-visual news service", she said, "I urge RSS family to make a special effort to increase their professional competencies and become self-sufficient."

The RSS also honoured the best journalists and employees on the occasion.

Minister Sharma presented the award to eight journalists and employees.

Senior Editor Krishna Sapkota has been awarded the best editor award, Senior Assistant Reporter Ashok Ghimire as best reporter and Account Officer Rajesh Kumar Shrestha as the best employee.

Similarly, Suresh Acharya (Surkhet) has been awarded as best photojournalist, Ram Bikas Chaudhary (Rupandehi) as the best feature writer, as well as Rupani GM (Banke), Manoj Dahal (Morang) and Niranjan Kumar Sah (Dhanusha) as best district correspondents.

All the award carries a purse of Rs 20,000 each.

Likewise, Minister Sharma honoured Radio Nepal, ratopati.com and Pratik Daily (Birgunj) as the best subscribers.

EU launches mission to protect ships in Red Sea from Houthis

AP
Brussels, Feb. 19

The European Union has launched Monday a naval mission to help protect cargo ships in the Red Sea as attacks by Houthi rebels in Yemen continue to threaten maritime traffic, hamper trade and drive up prices.

Dubbed Aspides, Greek for "shield," the mission will be run out of Larissa in central Greece — home to the Hellenic Air Force and a NATO headquarters — under the command of Greek Commodore Vasilios Griparis.

The Iranian-backed Houthis have waged a persistent campaign of drone and missile attacks on commercial ships over Israel's offensive in Gaza against Hamas which began in October.

However, the Yemen-based rebels have frequently targeted vessels with tenuous or no clear links to Israel, imperiling shipping in a key route for global trade between Asia, the Middle East and Europe.

In response, U.S. and British forces have bombed multiple targets used by the Houthis.

However, the EU mission will not take part in any military strikes and will only operate at sea.

"Within its defensive mandate, the operation will provide maritime situational awareness, accompany vessels, and protect them against possible multi-domain attacks at sea," EU headquarters said in a statement after the bloc's foreign ministers had endorsed the mission.

"The entire global economy is being hit. It's not just European ships that are repeatedly jeopardized by Houthi missiles in the Red Sea, but the entire international shipping industry," German Foreign Minister Annalena Baerbock told reporters in Brussels.

She said that apart from protecting European ships, the mission "makes it clear that we as an international community stand together in the face of attacks; terrorist attacks on the freedom of the sea lanes." Germany is contributing a frigate to the mission, as is Belgium.



PHOTO: BISHNU PRASAD POKHAREL

Artists performing at the fifth Damak Festival in Damak Jhapa. Several artists have been performing in Damak festival that kicked off on February 11 and will continue till February 24.

'Oppenheimer' wins 7 prizes at the British Academy Film Awards

AP
London, Feb 19

Atom bomb epic "Oppenheimer" won seven prizes, including best picture, director and actor, at the 77th British Academy Film Awards on Sunday, cementing its front-runner status for the Oscars next month.

Gothic fantasia "Poor Things" took five prizes and Holocaust drama "The Zone of Interest" won three.

British-born filmmaker Christopher Nolan won his first best director BAFTA for "Oppenheimer," and Irish performer Cillian Murphy won the best actor prize for playing physicist J. Robert Oppenheimer, the father of the atomic bomb.

Murphy said he was grateful to play such a "colossally knotty, complex character."

Nolan noted that nuclear weapons are "a nihilistic subject and the film inevitably reflects that," telling the movie's backers: "Thank you for taking on something dark."

Emma Stone was named best actress for playing the wild and spirited Bella Baxter in "Poor Things," a steampunk-style visual extravaganza that won prizes for visual effects, production design, makeup and hair and costume design.

"Oppenheimer" had a field-leading 13 nominations, but missed out on the record of nine trophies, set in 1971 by "Butch Cassidy and the Sundance Kid."

It won the best film race against "Poor Things," "Killers of the Flower Moon," "Anatomy of a Fall" and "The Holdovers." "Oppenheimer" also scooped trophies for editing, cinematography and musical score, as well as the best supporting actor prize for Robert Downey Jr., who played Atomic Energy Commission head Lewis Strauss.

Da'Vine Joy Randolph was named best supporting actress for playing a boarding school cook in "The Holdovers" and said she felt a "responsibility I don't take lightly" to tell the stories of underrepresented people like her character Mary.

"Oppenheimer" faced stiff competition in what's widely considered a vintage year for cinema and an awards season energized by the end of actors' and writers' strikes that shut down Hollywood for months.



PHOTO: AP

Kingsley Ben-Adir, from left, Cord Jefferson, winner of the adapted screenplay award for 'American Fiction', and Bryce Dallas Howard, pose for photographers at the 77th British Academy Film Awards, BAFTA's, in London, Sunday, Feb. 18, 2024.

" The Zone of Interest," a British-produced film shot in Poland with a largely German cast, was named both best British film and best film not in English — a first — and also took the prize for its sound, which has been described as the real star of the film.

Jonathan Glazer's unsettling drama takes place in a family home just outside the walls of the Auschwitz death camp, whose horrors are heard and hinted at, rather than seen.

Ukraine war documentary "20 Days in Mariupol," produced by The Associated Press and PBS "Frontline," won the prize for best documentary.

"This is not about us," said filmmaker Mstyslav Chernov, who captured the harrowing reality of life in the besieged city with an AP team. "This is about Ukraine, about the people of Mariupol."

Chernov said the story of the city and its fall into Russian occupation "is a symbol of struggle and a symbol of faith. Thank you for empowering our voice and let's just keep fighting."

The awards ceremony, hosted by "Doctor Who" star David Tennant — who entered wearing a kilt and sequined top while carrying a dog named Bark Ruffalo — was a glitzy, British-accented appetizer for Hollywood's Academy Awards, closely watched for hints about who might win at the Oscars on March 10.

The prize for original screenplay went to French courtroom drama "Anatomy of a Fall." The film about a woman on trial over the death of her husband was written by director Justine Triet and her partner, Arthur Harari. "It's a fiction, and we are reasonably fine," Triet joked.

Cord Jefferson won the adapted screenplay prize for the satirical "American Fiction," about the struggles of an African American novelist

Jefferson said he hoped the success of the movie "maybe changes the minds of the people who are in charge of greenlighting films and TV shows, allows them to be less risk-averse."

Historical epic "Killers of the Flower Moon," Leonard Bernstein biopic "Maestro," grief-flecked love story "All of Us Strangers" and class-war dramedy "Saltburn " all won nothing despite multiple nominations.

" Barbie," one half of 2023's "Barbenheimer" box office juggernaut and the year's top-grossing film, also came up empty from five nominations. "Barbie" director Greta Gerwig failed to get a directing nomination for either the BAFTAs or the Oscars, in what was seen by many as a major snub.

Britain's film academy introduced changes to increase the awards' diversity in 2020, when no women were nominated as best director for the seventh year running and all 20 nominees in the lead and supporting performer categories were white. However, Triet was the only woman among this year's six best-director nominees. The Rising Star award, the only category decided by public vote, went to Mia McKenna-Bruce, star of "How to Have Sex."

Before the ceremony, nominees, including Bradley Cooper, Carey Mulligan, Emily Blunt, Rosamund Pike, Ryan Gosling and Ayo Edebiri all walked the red carpet at London's Royal Festival Hall, along with presenters Andrew Scott, Cate Blanchett, Idris Elba and David Beckham.

Guest of honor was Prince William, in his role as president of the British Academy of Film and Television Arts. He arrived without his wife, Kate, who is recovering from abdominal surgery last month.

The ceremony included musical performances by "Ted Lasso" star Hannah Waddingham, singing "Time After Time," and Sophie Ellis-Bextor, singing her 2001 hit "Murder on the Dancefloor," which shot back up the charts after featuring in "Saltburn."

Film curator June Givanni, founder of the June Givanni PanAfrican Cinema Archive, was honored for outstanding British contribution to cinema, while actress Samantha Morton received the academy's highest honor, the BAFTA Fellowship. Morton, who grew up in foster care and children's homes, said that "representation matters."

"The stories we tell, they have the power to change people's lives," she said. "Film changed my life, it transformed me, and it led me here today."

Saudi Arabia's Film AlUla Unveils Music Recording Studio in the Works



PHOTO: AGENCY

'Kandahar' was one of the first international productions to shoot in Saudi Arabia.

AGENCY
New Delhi, Feb 19

Saudi Arabia's Film AlUla is getting into the music business.

The country's official film agency has unveiled plans for a music recording studio to complement its recently launched film studio complex. Film AlUla plans to open in June 2024 a recording studio with a control room and booths to be used by music artists, choirs, rehearsals for film score production, music videos and orchestral work.

Film AlUla's already opened two 26,000-square-foot soundstages with workshops and a backlot for short term infrastructure and set builds. Saudi Arabia is, through huge investments, offering a full-service creative hub as the country looks to host more concerts and festivals with facilities for fully-fledged movie and music making amid the sand dunes, desert oases and ancient ruins of the country's historic Incense Route, which in turn is home to Saudi Arabia's first UNESCO World Heritage Site.

What to stream this week: 'Avatar: The Last Airbender,' 'Priscilla' and Dolly Parton's puppies

AP
New York, Feb 19

Dolly Parton hosting a two-hour puppy-filled variety special on CBS and the seventh and final season of the hospital drama, "The Good Doctor" are some of the new television, movies, music and games headed to a device near you.

Also among the streaming offerings worth your time as selected by The Associated Press' entertainment journalists: Andrew Lincoln and Danai Gurira return to "The Walking Dead" universe in their own spin-off, "The Walking Dead: The Ones Who Live" and "Avatar: The Last Airbender" gets the live-action treatment by Netflix.

It missed out on Oscar nominations, but Andrew Haigh's "All of Us Strangers" was one of the best films of 2023. The film, which debuts on Hulu on Thursday, stars Andrew Scott as a writer working on an autobiographical script, work that transports him back to his childhood home where he finds his long dead parents (Claire Foy, Jamie Bell) as they once were. At the same time, a romance with a neighbor (Paul Mescal) evolves. Metaphysical and melancholy, "All of Us Strangers" is a stunner that AP Film Writer Lindsey Bahr called an "a deeply felt journey of acceptance, love and forgiveness" in her review. Another near-miss with the Oscars, Sofia Coppola's "Priscilla," hits Max on Friday, Feb. 23. Coppola's dreamy, textured tale of Priscilla Presley's surreal romance with Elvis produced two of last year's most memorably breakthrough performances in Cailee Spaeny and Jacob Elordi. In my review, I praised "Priscilla" as "a kind of fairy tale that turns claustrophobic and cautionary."



PHOTO: AP

This combination of photos shows promotional art for "Priscilla," streaming Feb. 23 on Max, left, "Avatar: The Last Airbender," streaming Feb. 22 on Netflix, center, and "All of Us Strangers," a film streaming Feb. 22 on Hulu.

Two notable veterans of last year's Oscar race, both from A24, arrive this week on Netflix. " Everything Everywhere All at Once, " Daniel Kwan and Daniel Scheinert's multiverse romp arrives Friday, Feb. 23, almost exactly a year after the anarchic sci-fi whatsit's improbable Academy Awards sweep.

French Riviera carnivals celebrate pop culture and Paris Olympics

AP
France, Feb. 19

As most of Europe moves into the solemn weeks before Easter, the party is just getting started on the French Rivera.

The Mediterranean town of Menton showcased its lush citrus and celebrated the upcoming Olympics in Paris during its Carnival parade on Sunday. Sculptures of athletes assembled from lemons and oranges decorated the streets and rode on giant floats.

Nice, the Rivera's capital, kicked off its annual Carnival season on Saturday night with a pop culture-themed parade of lights and extravagant floats that featured "Star Wars" character Luke Skywalker as king and Marilyn Monroe, clad in a Superwoman costume, as his queen.

Both festivals on the French Mediterranean coast are derived from a medieval Mardi Gras tradition of staging public spectacles for visiting European nobles. Modern versions of Carnival over the past century have mocked politicians and ridiculed public figures.

But the weekend parades in Nice and Menton avoided divisive politics and grim events, focusing instead on recognizing achievements in film, music, art and sports. "We wanted to honor the Olympics because Paris is hosting the Games," Christophe Ghiena, the technical director of Menton's Lemon Festival, or "Fête du Citron," said.

The theme of the 90th edition of the Lemon Festival was "From Olympia to Menton." Ten floats carried giant figures of tennis, rugby and badminton players, a boxer, a swimmer, an equestrian athlete and a surfer called John Lemon down a seaside boardwalk as visitors doubled the town's population of 33,000.

HOROSCOPE

tarot.com

Aries: Feeling like you're not good enough could weigh you down at this time. While the sensitive Moon in your brooding 4th house aligns with liberating Uranus in your resource zone, taking an inventory of what you have going.

Taurus: You may currently feel like you can't say anything without offending someone else. As a result, you could be holding a lot inside. Thoughtfully releasing some of the tension should allow you to avoid impulsively blowing up.

Gemini: Getting jealous of a peer's income or possessions is a present risk for you. While the anxious Moon in your finance sector trips into provocative Chiron in your social zone, the other person may not have any negative intentions toward.

Cancer: A critical response from an authority figure could really wound you today. Perhaps you've been working hard to earn their approval and seem to come up short no matter what you do. As the vulnerable Moon in your sign.

Leo: Your beliefs about the way the world works could be causing you distress at the moment. Before you let your anxieties motivate you to take action, you may want to look again at whether your assumptions are accurate.

Virgo: Finding comfortable boundaries when you socialize could be challenging now. While the connection-seeking Moon in your friendship sector misunderstands wounded Chiron in your intimacy zone, you may suspect that holding important.

Libra: You may currently feel like you must choose between pursuing a personal goal and maintaining your loyalty to a valued relationship. Perhaps renegotiating the terms of your commitment to the other person is more possible than you think.

Scorpio: Having a resentful attitude toward your responsibilities is now possible. While the impulsive Moon in your adventure sector goads touchy Chiron in your 6th House of Work, you may wish you could be doing something fun instead.

Sagittarius: A growing relationship could presently nudge you to tear down some of your walls. While the inquisitive Moon in your intimacy zone aggravates tender Chiron in your 5th House of Self-Expression.

Capricorn: Insecurities from your early life could be reawakened by a recent close relationship. While the spontaneous Moon in your partnership zone provokes moody Chiron in your 4th House of Roots.

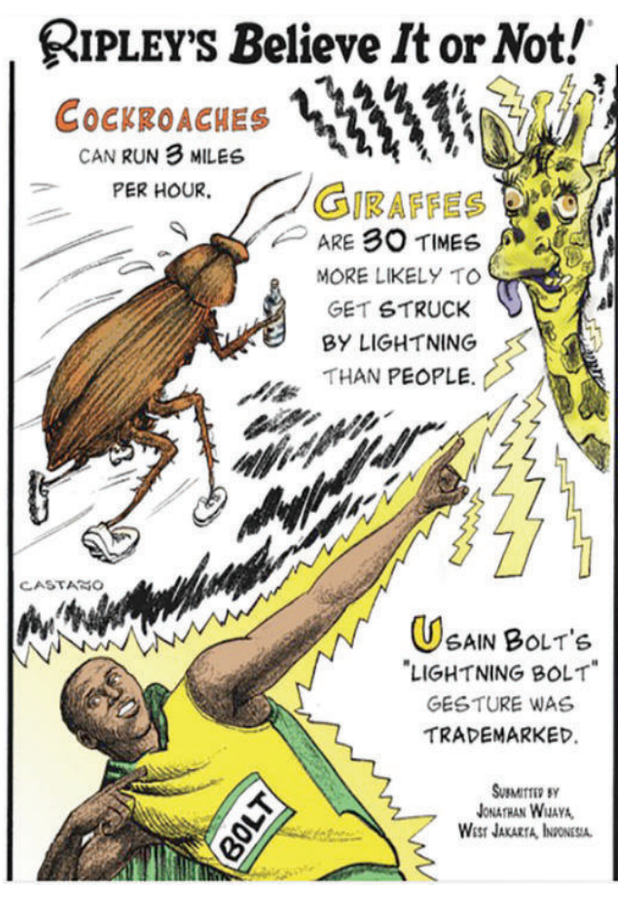
Aquarius: Your critical attitude could currently come out in a conversation about routine tasks. Is it truly necessary to take things to that level? As the comfort-craving Moon in your responsible 6th house.

Pisces: Sticking to a tight budget could be a high priority for you. Of course, feeling like you can't afford any self-indulgence probably only makes you want it more. Remind yourself that there are many ways to find the fun and stimulation you're craving.

CARTOON

gocomics.com





MIAMI EXPECTS TROPHIES FROM MESSI'S FIRST FULL SEASON IN MLS



AFP
Miami, Feb. 19

Lionel Messi and Inter Miami get the new Major League Soccer season under way on Wednesday with pressure on the Argentine star to deliver trophies for his club and more eyeballs on the league.

The World Cup winner joined Inter from Paris Saint Germain in mid-July, the biggest name ever to move to MLS and his signing caused a massive spurt in interest in American soccer.

The eight-times and current Ballon d'Or winner, made an instant impact, leading Miami to the Leagues Cup title, packing stadiums and massively increasing subscriptions to Apple TV's MLS Season Pass broadcast package.

But the excitement waned as the 36-year-old struggled to maintain his fitness in the face of a hectic schedule and Miami were unable to overcome their poor early season results and make the playoffs.

Then Inter's decision to undertake a gruelling overseas pre-season tour backfired with Messi and the team booed in Hong Kong after the star sat out a high-profile friendly due to injury.

Poor performances added to the sense that money-spinning trips to El Salvador, Saudi Arabia and Japan had been a mis-step for a team looking to hit the ground running this season.

A long and busy season awaits for Messi and his team-mates who as well as competing in MLS, have qualified for the regional CONCACAF Champions Cup.

Miami will also aim to defend their Leagues Cup title -- against Mexican as well as MLS opposition -- and all those challenges come in a summer which will include Argentina's bid for the Copa America in the USA.

Messi has been joined in Miami by another veteran striker in Uruguayan Luis Suarez, making up a quartet of former Barcelona players with midfielder Sergio Busquets and left-back Jordi Alba.

No MLS team has ever been able to draw on players of such pedigree and experience and with that comes the expectation that they will land the club's first MLS title.

Messi is well used to such pressure but it is a new sensation for some of the younger players in Gerardo Martino's squad.

Shanyder Borgelin, the 22-year-old striker who scored in last week's home friendly against Argentine club Newells Old Boys, says the team can cope with the high expectations.

"That's expected when you have the greatest player in the world, four of the greatest players in the world, but I think we're ready," he told the Miami Herald.

"We are all called up to a big task. I definitely think the (preseason) losses and everything that comes with that made us a lot stronger," he added.

Miami kick-off their campaign on Wednesday at home to Real Salt Lake with the rest of the league getting under way on Saturday.

Spinner Dutt stars as Netharlands trounce Namibia by seven wickets

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Feb. 19



Off-spinner Aryan Dutt starred with his bowl as the Netherlands thumped Namibia by seven wickets in the second edition of ICC Cricket World Cup League 2 on Monday. The win also opened the account for the Dutch side in the League 2 standings. The Netherlands suffered a nine-wicket loss against Host Nepal in their first match played on Saturday.

Winning the toss at TU Cricket Ground, the Netherlands invited Namibia to bat first and bundled the Eagles out for 123 runs in 35.1 overs. The Dutch, in their chase, got off to a positive start with Michael Levitt and Max O'Dowd pairing for a 78-run openi1ng stand. Namibian Captain Gerhard Erasmus bowled out Max to break the partnership in 15.4 overs. Max added 28 runs that included two fours and two boundaries. Erasmus then trapped Sybrand Engelbrecht (6) for lbw as his second victim in 19.6 overs. Levit achieved his maiden ODI fifty before being caught by Jan Frylinck off Erasmus in 23.4 overs. Levit cracked eight boundaries and two sixes in his 81-ball 57 knocks.

Bas de Leede (not out 21) and Captain Scot Edwards (not out 4) completed the chase in 27.2 overs.

Earlier, it was bowler Aryan who led the Netherlands bowling onslaught in the collapse of Namibia.

Aryan finished with his career-best of 6-34 bowling figures. He also became the first bowler for his country to take six wickets in men's ODI. The spinner's figures surpassed Timm van der Gugten's 5-24 against Canada in 2013.

Aryan's 5-12 in his first 18 balls was almost the fastest to a five-wicket haul in ODI cricket by balls bowled. Mohammed Siraj, Chaminda Vaas and Ali Khan had five wickets in 16 balls.

The 20-year-old trapped Michael van Lingen (4) for lbw was his first wicket. He bowled out Opener JP Kotze (5) for his second, again trapped Jan Frylinck lbw for his third, made Captain Gerhard (13) catch out for his fourth and bowled Jan Nicol Loftie-Eaton (0) for his fifth wicket.

He picked Zane Green (19) as his sixth wicket in 20.4 overs. Johannes Jonathan Smit (26), Riben Trunpelmann (20) Bernard Scholtz and Opener Nikolaas Davin (13) contributed with the double figure but could not make their stay at the crease long. Kyle Klein picked two while Roelof van der Merwe and Max O'Dowd claimed one wicket each for the Netherlands.

Namibia will now face Nepal in their third match on Wednesday at Kirtipur.

SNIPPETS

Nepal to compete in T20 Tri-Series

Kathmandu (TRN): Nepal will be competing in the Friendship Cup T20 Tri-Series, the Cricket Association of Nepal (CAN) said on Monday. The CAN, Baroda Cricket Association and Gujarat Cricket Association have agreed to participate in the Tri-Series organized by Sai Meghpan Sporrtslife (SMS), stated a press release. The event will kick off with Nepal taking against Gujrat on March 31 at the facilities of SMS in Vapi, India. The top two teams from the double round-robin league will fight for the title on April 7. The Friendship Cup T20 Tri-Series will also be a platform for the Nepal National Cricket Team to enhance their skills and gain valuable exposure against the state teams of the BCCI, according to the release. The CAN said the event is a crucial step towards Nepal's preparation for the ICC Men's T20 World Cup 2024.

Parki to compete in London Marathon

Kathmandu (TRN): Gopichandra Parki, the winner of the 9th edition of the Nepalgunj Marathon, is set to participate in the London Marathon on April 21. Nepalgunj Marathon confirmed Parki's participation in a press meet held on Monday. Parki, who has won the Nepalgunj Marathon twice, expressed his desire to achieve the best results in London. Nepal UK Run will be managing Parki during the London Marathon. Santosh Rai, a representative of UK Run, said that an effort will be made to include the winner of the half-marathon along with the Nepalgunj Marathon winner. Tanka Lal Ghising, the Member Secretary of the National Sports Council, wished Parki the best of luck and assured continued support from the council to the marathon. Parki completed the 9th edition of the Nepalgunj Marathon in 2 hours and 21.38 minutes. He was also the gold medalist in the 5000m race during the 13th South Asian Games held in Nepal in 2019.

Madhes wins U16 cricket title

Pokhara (TRN): Madhes Pradesh emerged victorious in the Manmohan Memorial U-16 National Cricket Tournament on Monday. Madhes defeated Sudurpaschim Province by five wickets in the final, which was held at Pokhara Stadium. After bowling out Sudurpaschim for 86 runs in 20.2 overs, Madhes achieved the target, losing just five wickets in 20.1 overs. Chandan Ram, the all-rounder from Madhes, was named the Player of the Tournament. He took 10 wickets and scored 83 runs in the tournament. The best bowler of the tournament award went to Dambar Majhi of Sudurpaschim, who took 14 wickets in five matches. Similarly, Rahul Hag Ansari of Madhes was named the best batsman for his 152 runs off five matches.

Man United's Hojlund makes Premier League history

AFP
Luton, Feb. 19



Rasmus Hojlund made Premier League history as the Manchester United striker's double ensured his side survived a scare from lowly Luton in their 2-1 win on Sunday.

Hojlund became the youngest player to score in six consecutive Premier League games after netting twice in the first seven minutes at Kenilworth Road.

At 21 years 14 days old, Hojlund surpassed Newcastle midfielder Joe Willock's previous record set when he was 21 years 272 days old.

Ruud van Nistelrooy scored in 10 successive United top-flight outings in 2003 before Leicester's Jamie Vardy beat his Premier league record with 11 in a row in 2015.

After failing to score in his first 14 Premier League appearances following his August move from Atalanta, Hojlund has scored eight times in his last eight games in all competitions.

His brace should have put United in complete control, but Luton fought back impressively as Carlton Morris quickly reduced the deficit.

Erik ten Hag's side were under seige for spells and wasted several chances to kill off fourth-bottom Luton in a tense finale.

Praising Hojlund's mentality, Ten Hag said: "We recruited him on his character, I knew it was strong.

"He can really perform under stress and that is something you need from a Man United striker.

"He doesn't get nervous or lose confidence. He has a lot of confidence and I'm sure he will score even more."

Hojlund added: "I need to say thanks to my teammates and the coach because they have showed me great confidence and kept believing in me.

"I knew as well that I could score goals but of course it was annoying I didn't score in the Premier League."

Sixth placed United's fourth consecutive league victory moved them within five points of fourth placed Aston Villa in the race to qualify for next season's Champions League.

With just 37 seconds gone, Hojlund intercepted Amari'i Bell's dreadful back pass, rounded keeper Thomas Kaminski and slotted into the empty net.

United's fastest league goal this season was followed by Hojlund's second in the seventh minute.

When Alejandro Garnacho smashed a volley towards goal from a United corner, the strike hit Hojlund's chest and deflected into the net.

But Morris gave Luton an unexpected lifeline in the 14th minute when the burly striker headed in from close-range after Tahith Chong's shot deflected into his path.

WEATHER

Tuesday

Sunrise at 6:38 am, Sunset at 5:58 pm

Forecast for Nepal (Tuesday)

Generally cloudy in the hilly areas and Gandaki Province, Lumbini Province, Karnali Province and Sudur Pashchim Province and partly cloudy to mainly fair in rest of the country. Light to moderate rain is likely to occur at some places of Gandaki Province, Lumbini Province, Karnali Province and Sudur Pashchim Province and at a few places of rest of the country. Possibility of light to moderate snowfall at some places of the western high mountainous region of the country and at a few places of high mountainous region of rest of the country.

Expected Temp.: 21-23 Rain Probability: 0%

Monday's Weather Record

Stations	Max. temp. (C)	Min. temp. (C)	Rain (mm)
Dipayal	27.2	10.1	Traces
Dadeldhura	20.0	6.8	Traces
Dhangadi	26.2	11.5	0.0
Birendranagar	26.6	9.5	0.0
Nepalgunj	27.4	13.0	0.0
Jumla	19.2	1.5	0.0
Ghorahi	25.0	11.4	0.0
Pokhara	23.4	12.0	0.0
Bhairahawa	28.2	11.5	0.0
Simara	27.0	12.0	0.0
Kathmandu	21.8	7.8	0.0
Okhaldhunga	19.1	8.0	0.0
Taplejung	17.0	7.6	0.0
Dhankuta	21.9	9.5	0.0
Biratnagar	27.4	10.3	0.0
Jomsom	11.0	-2.5	0.0*
Dharan	27.0	15.0	0.0*
Lumle	17.1	7.2	0.0*
Janakpur	29.0	11.0	0.0*
Jiri	16.9	1.9	0.0*

NEPAL RASTRA BANK

FOREIGN EXCHANGE DEPARTMENT

EXCHANGE RATES

February 20, 2024

CURRENCY	UNIT	BUYING	SELLING
Indian Rupee	100	Rs. 160.00	Rs. 160.15

Open Market Exchange Rates
For the purpose of Nepal Rastra Bank

CURRENCY	UNIT	BUYING	SELLING
U.S. Dollar	1	Rs. 132.53	Rs. 133.13
Euro	1	Rs. 142.87	Rs. 143.51
Pound Sterling	1	Rs. 167,25	Rs. 168.01
Swiss Franc	1	Rs. 150.55	Rs. 151.23
Australian Dollar	1	Rs. 86.66	Rs. 87.05
Canadian Dollar	1	Rs. 98.34	Rs. 98.79
Singapore Dollar	1	Rs. 98.48	Rs. 98.93
Japanese Yen	10	Rs. 8.84	Rs. 8.88
Chinese Yuan	1	Rs. 18.41	Rs. 18.50
Saudi Arab Riyal	1	Rs. 35.34	Rs. 35.50
Qatari Riyal	1	Rs. 36.34	Rs. 36.51
Thai Bhat	1	Rs. 3.68	Rs. 3.70
UAE Dirham	1	Rs. 36.08	Rs. 36.25
Malaysian Ringgit	1	Rs. 27.69	Rs. 27.81
South Korean Won	100	Rs. 9.93	Rs. 9.97
Swedish Kronar	1	Rs. 12.71	Rs. 12.77
Danish Kronar	1	Rs. 19.17	Rs. 19.25
Hong Kong Dollar	1	Rs. 16.95	Rs. 17.02
Kuwaiti Dinar	1	Rs. 430.40	Rs. 432.35
Bahrain Dinar	1	Rs. 351.56	Rs. 353.15

Note: Under the present system the open market exchange rates quoted by different banks may differ.

Bayern Munich's era of dominance nearing end

AP
Berlin, Feb. 19

It feels like the beginning of the end of an era for Bayern Munich.

The Bavarian powerhouse lost again Sunday, and its chances of securing a record-extending 12th consecutive Bundesliga title look slim as league leader Bayer Leverkusen pulled eight points clear with 12 rounds remaining.

It was Bayern's third defeat in eight days, a run that started with a chastening 3-0 loss at Leverkusen, then a 1-0 defeat at Lazio in the Champions League, before Bochum came from behind to win 3-2 in the Bundesliga on Sunday. "It feels like a horror film that just doesn't end," Bayern midfielder Leon Goretzka said.

Bayern hadn't lost three games in a row since May 2015, when the team coached by Pep Guardiola had already clinched the Bundesliga title and was focused on the Champions League.

The situation is vastly different now as Bayern can't afford any more slip-ups either domestically or in the Champions League, with Lazio visiting for the second leg of their round-of-16 match on March 5.

Even if Bayern does manage to advance, Thomas Tuchel's team does not look capable of upsetting tournament favorites like Manchester City or Real Madrid.

Of greatest concern for Bayern, however, is the disappearance of its aura of domestic superiority — Bayern is not the best team in Germany anymore as Leverkusen clearly demonstrated in its win over the defending champion.

Tuchel's team was already knocked out of the German Cup by third-division Saarbrücken in the second round. And Bayern only won the Bundesliga title last year because Borussia Dortmund squandered its chance on the final day.

Rivals no longer fear the Bavarian powerhouse. Bochum — a team that Bayern defeated 7-0 in Munich earlier this season — fought hard and took its chances. It also needed veteran goalkeeper Manuel Riemann at his best to deny Leroy Sané late on as Bayern had 27 shots compared to Bochum's 13.

Tuchel blamed bad luck for the defeat, but Bochum displayed more commitment than his players. Bayern was at its best when Tuchel sent on the 18-year-old French forward Mathys Tel, who perhaps should have started. Bayern midfielder Joshua Kimmich clashed with assistant coach Zsolt Löw after the match, suggesting tensions between players and the coaching staff.

Tuchel himself stayed in the dugout for most of the second half while Bochum counterpart Thomas Letsch had the sideline to himself to urge on his players.

Bayern chief executive Jan-Christian Dreesen said Tuchel will remain in charge for Bayern's next match against visiting Leipzig on Saturday, but he didn't rule out making a change at a later stage.

Bayern's struggles have come despite summer signing Harry Kane scoring 25 goals in 22 games so far, topping the Bundesliga scoring chart by a wide margin. But much has been made in the German press of Bayern's other highly paid stars — Kimmich, Goretzka, Sané, Serge Gnabry and Matthijs de Ligt — and their failure to meet expectations.

Tuchel, who took over from the fired Julian Nagelsmann less than a year ago, is encountering the same problems as his predecessor, who had taken over from Hansi Flick in 2021. Oliver Kahn, who was Bayern CEO at the time, said Bayern wasn't showing its true potential under Nagelsmann.

But Kahn is gone now, too, fired along with sporting director Hasan Salihamidži at the end of last season just hours after Bayern's title win.

It continued the boardroom upheaval that started when former club president Uli Hoeness stepped down in 2019 and former CEO Karl-Heinz Rummenigge followed in 2021. Both Hoeness and Rummenigge are on Bayern's supervisory board.

Published by Executive Chairman **Bishnu Prasad Subedi** and General Manager **Lal Bahadur Airi** for the Gorkhapatra Corporation • Printed at G.S. Press, Kathmandu • Acting Editor-in-Chief: **Bhimsen Thapaliya**
Phone: Editorial 5322279 • Advertisement 5327493, 5331394 • Distribution 5320638 • E-mail: mgorkhapatra@gmail.com, trnfeatures@hotmail.com • Registered No. 29/028/022 • G.P.O. 30/053/54